Statistical Inference for AI-Agent Leaderboards: Record Claims, Rank Uncertainty and the Winner's Curse

Jeffery Opoku[1,*] David Banahene[2]

[1]School of Mathematical and Statistical Sciences, University of Texas Rio Grande Valley, Edinburg, TX 78539, USA

[2]Department of Biostatistics, Robert Stempel College of Public Health and Social Work, Florida International University, Miami, FL 33199, USA

[*]Corresponding author: jeffery.opoku01@utrgv.edu

Draft of 13 October 2026

Abstract

A leaderboard for AI agents gives every system one score on a fixed list of tasks and announces a new record whenever a submission scores higher than everything before it. But a benchmark is only a sample of tasks, so some records are luck: a different draw of tasks would have given a different winner. We check every record on six public agent leaderboards that publish results task by task (SWE-bench Verified, Lite, Test, Multimodal and Multilingual, and Terminal-Bench 2). The check is a simple exact test on the tasks where the two systems disagree, run in a way that takes into account that we only look at a record because it scored higher; we prove the test stays honest even though the old record was itself the best of everything before it. 20 of the 74 records (27%) are clearly better than the record they replaced; 13 remain after a correction for testing many records; and only 10 of the 65 SWE-bench records remain when we count code repositories instead of tasks, the cautious count. When we split the real tasks into two random halves, records that pass the test on one half beat the old record on the other half 0.92 of the time, against 0.47 for pure luck. Records arrive one by one, so we also give rules for certifying them as they come, and we prove that three of these rules keep the chance of ever certifying a false record below 5%, no matter how many records arrive or how they depend on each other; they certify 11 of the 74 records. The reason most records cannot be confirmed is resolution: SWE-bench Verified (500 tasks) can reliably see a true gap of about 4.3 points, a typical record there wins by 1.5 points, and seeing a one-point gap would need about 9,300 tasks. On Verified, 14 of 135 systems could be the true best. The top score is also inflated simply because it was picked for being the highest: by 2.2 points when the leaders are truly equal on 500 tasks; a bootstrap correction removes about 84% of that (± 8 points), and we compare it with two published corrections. Tuning a system on the public tasks is not covered. We release `honestboard`, a small Python package that computes all of this for any leaderboard with task-by-task results.

1 Introduction

A leaderboard takes a big table of results, one row per system and one column per task, and boils it down to one score per system and one ranking. Everyone then uses that ranking: papers claim a new state of the art, companies compare products, and users pick tools. The ranking is treated as a fact, but it is really an estimate. SWE-bench Verified [24] has 500 tasks. Two agents that differ

by a point and a half on those tasks actually disagree on only a few dozen of them, and which agent wins on those few depends on which tasks happened to be in the benchmark.

We call a *record step* a submission that scores higher than every earlier submission on its leaderboard, in date order; the *record it replaced* is the previous record holder. Using the task-by-task results that several leaderboards publish, we ask four questions.

1. **Records.** When a submission sets a new record, is it really better than the record it replaced, or could the gap be luck?

2. **Resolution.** What is the smallest true gap a benchmark can reliably see, and how does that compare with the gaps records are claimed by?

3. **Ranks.** How much does the top of the ranking move if we redraw the tasks, and which systems might really be the best?

4. **Winner's curse.** The top score was picked because it was the highest of many noisy scores. How much does it overstate how good the system really is, and can we correct for that?

Findings. Across 74 record steps on 5 leaderboards, 20 (27%) are clearly better than the record they replaced, using a test that allows for the fact that we only look at records because they scored higher; 13 (18%) remain after a correction for testing many records on one board; and 10 of the 65 SWE-bench records remain when code repositories, not tasks, are treated as the unit that was sampled (Section 6). The pattern follows the size of the benchmark: SWE-bench Test, with 2,294 tasks, confirms 9 of its 13 records, while the 5 boards with at most 510 tasks confirm 11 of 61. Figure 1 shows every record on four boards and Figure 4 shows why: on these boards a typical record wins by less than the smallest gap the board can reliably see. Among 135 submissions, pure luck would produce about 4.5 records; Verified has 30, so the leaderboard does track real progress, but most single records are too small for the board to confirm. Rankings wobble in the same way: two systems tie for first on Verified, the one that ranks first most often does so in only 0.35 of redraws of the tasks, and 14 of the 135 systems could be the true best. Terminal-Bench 2 has a clear leader (first in 0.80 of redraws), so the tools do not always say "noise". They work the same way on a leaderboard of plain language models: on LiveBench (318 questions) 4 of 4 records pass the basic test and 1 passes the correction for many tests, too few records to compare with the agent boards (Section 6). The winner's reported score is inflated, and a bootstrap correction removes most of the inflation when we check on tasks held back at random, with the caveats in Section 5. None of this means the records are fake or that two systems are equal: a record that we cannot confirm may still be better; the data just cannot show it.

Relation to earlier work. Careful statistics for AI evaluation is not new: error bars for language-model scores [5, 16, 32, 35], power calculations for benchmark comparisons [6], comparisons of agents that account for cost [25], run-to-run intervals for coding agents [20], the effect of the scaffolding around a model [2, 49, 54], and tests for whether a new model version got worse [28]. Three recent papers are close to ours. Liu et al. [31] run exact McNemar tests on neighbouring pairs in four SWE-bench leaderboards, find that no neighbouring pair in the Verified top 30 can be told apart, and estimate how many tasks that would take; what we add is the audit of records in time order, the repository-level test, Terminal-Bench, the set of possible best systems, the winner's-curse correction and the tool. Kotawala [27] give the same kind of resolution numbers (smallest detectable gap, tasks needed) for paired evaluations of language models, which our resolution section applies to agent boards. Jain [22] argues, with simulations tuned to language-model leaderboards, that the

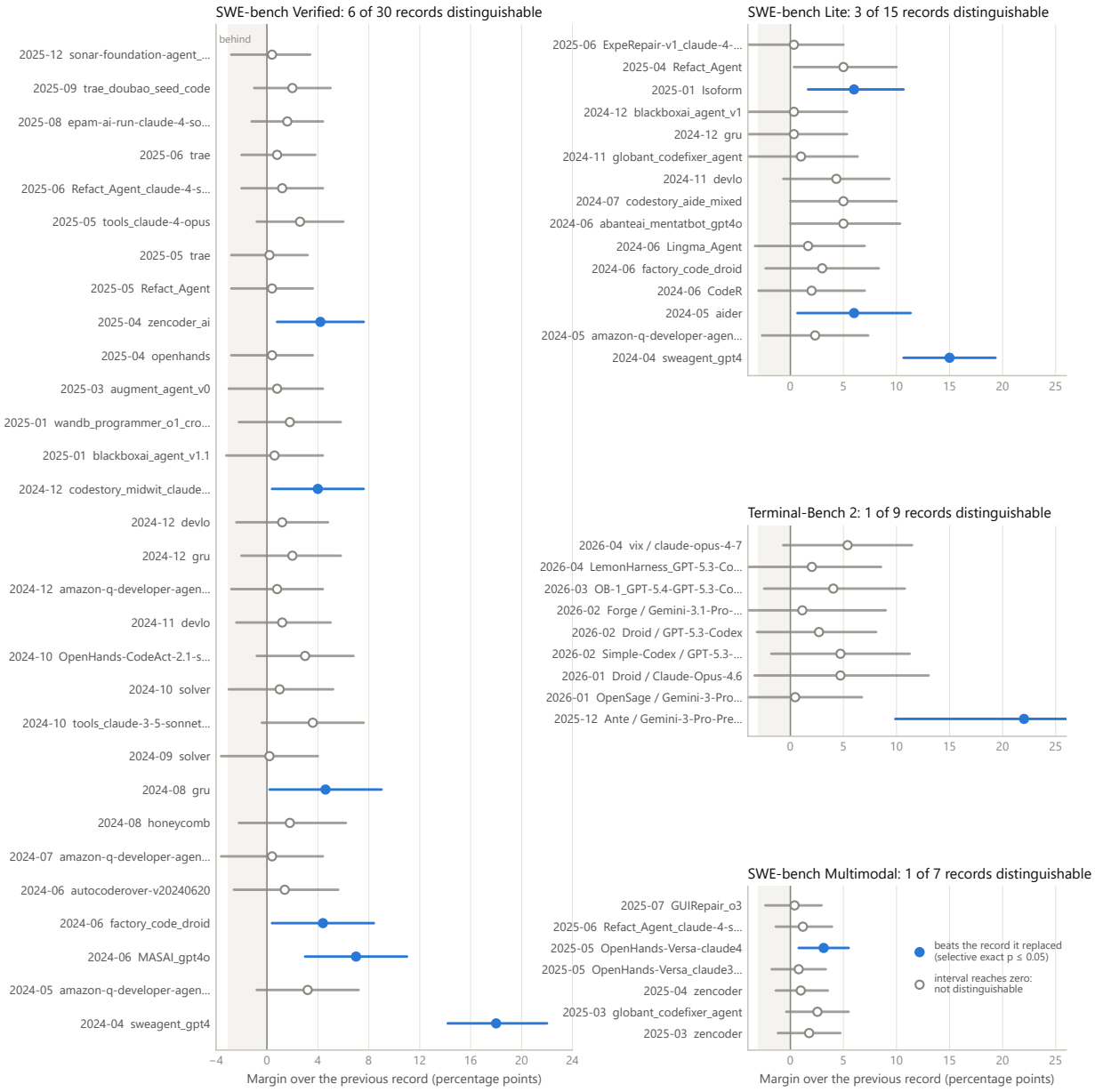


Figure 1: Every record on four public leaderboards. Each row is a submission that set a new record; the dot is how far it beat the old record and the bar is the range the gap could plausibly take (95% interval, from redrawing the tasks). Blue: the record is clearly better than the one before it (our test, $p \leq 0.05$). Gray: it is not. Newest at the top. SWE-bench Test (9 of 13 records clearly better) and Multilingual (no records under our ordering) are not shown.

top-ranked model is the true best only some of the time, and builds sets of plausible winners with a paired bootstrap and a Holm correction; it names models arriving over time as future work, which is exactly our setting. The rules we use for records that arrive one by one come from the literature on testing many hypotheses in sequence: alpha-investing [14], online false-discovery-rate rules [23, 41], online family-wise error control [48] and the Ladder mechanism for leaderboards [4]; what is new here is the p-value for a single record step and the proof that the rules keep their guarantee even though the record chain itself decides which hypotheses get tested. Rank intervals for leaderboards are developed by Neuhof and Benjamini [37, 38], with roots in Mogstad et al. [36] and Hung and Fithian [21]; sets of possible best models in Hansen et al. [15] and Kim and Ramdas [26]; Chatbot Arena reports bootstrap intervals and rank sets [7, 8]. On the winner's curse, Andrews et al. [1], Zrnic and Fithian [56], Petrou-Zeniou and Shaikh [40] and Hoff and Tokdar [17] give corrections for a winner that has already been picked, and Bakshi et al. [3] one that adds randomness; we use the conditional method of Fithian et al. [13], Lee et al. [29] and an iterated bootstrap [10, 11], and run the hybrid of Andrews et al. [1] and the zoom interval of Zrnic and Fithian [56] as baselines. Inflation from teams quietly trying many versions before submitting [44, 52] and from overfitting to a benchmark [42] are the kinds of error this paper does not model. An informal bootstrap analysis of Terminal-Bench 2 that grouped tasks reached a similar conclusion about its top two entries [30].

Contributions. This is an audit paper with a tested tool, plus one piece of new statistics. (i) The audit: every record on six public agent leaderboards, checked with an exact test that allows for how records are selected and with a repository-level test, compared against what each benchmark can resolve; a split-half check on the real data; a language-model leaderboard run through the same pipeline; and a bound on how much reporting the best of several runs would inflate a score, from the one board that has repeated runs. (ii) The new statistics: a way to certify records as they arrive. We give a p-value for a record step that stays valid even though we only test a step because it is a record and even though the old record was itself the best of everything before it (Proposition 1), two rules for setting the bar at each step, alpha-spending and online fallback, that keep the chance of ever certifying a false record below 5% no matter how records depend on each other (Corollaries 1 and 2), the same guarantee for the version in which the leader only changes when a record is certified (Corollary 3), and an online false-discovery-rate variant checked by simulation (Section 3). As far as we know this is the first certification rule for leaderboard records with a guarantee of this kind. (iii) Rank intervals and a set of possible best systems, with a check of how often they contain the truth, and a corrected score for the published winner, checked by simulation and on held-back tasks with error bars for the simulation itself, against the hybrid of Andrews et al. [1] and the zoom interval of Zrnic and Fithian [56]. What is proved and what is only simulated: the per-step test is exact under its stated null, and the error over a whole chain is controlled for three rules; everything else, including LORD++, the winner correction and the set of possible best systems, rests on simulation and held-back data. Table 2 in Section 3 says which is which. (iv) `honestboard`, a small Python package with a command line and a check for new submissions,[1] and a short list of things leaderboards should report.

2 Setting

A benchmark has T tasks and K systems. System k gets a result $y_{kt} \in [0, 1]$ on task t: a pass (1) or fail (0) when each task is run once, or the share of repeated runs that passed. The reported score

[1] Version 0.1.0, MIT licence: https://github.com/jopoku16/honestboard, with the built boards, every result file, the scripts behind each table and figure, and the manuscript source.

is the average, $\widehat{p}_k = T^{-1}\sum_t y_{kt}$. What we actually want to know is $\theta_k = \mathbb{E}[y_{kt}]$: the score system k, exactly as submitted, would get on average over all tasks of the kind the benchmark samples from. In other words, we treat the tasks as the thing that was sampled. Every system is scored on the same tasks, so the scores move together (a hard task is hard for everyone), and every comparison between two systems is a paired comparison, task by task. We estimate how the scores co-vary by $\widehat{\Sigma}_{ij} = \{T(T-1)\}^{-1}\sum_t (y_{it} - \bar{y}_i)(y_{jt} - \bar{y}_j)$. Where tasks come in groups (the code repository they belong to) we also use a version of this that sums within groups, and a bootstrap that resamples groups.

What the numbers are about. Everything below is about θ_k in that sense: the score a system would get on more tasks of the same kind as the benchmark's (the same repositories, the same kinds of problems, the same scoring). It is not about repositories the benchmark does not contain, about real-world use, or about a system after it has been tuned further. A reported score has three parts: the true score θ_k, luck in which tasks were drawn, and inflation from development, because teams tune their systems, and sometimes train them, with the public tasks in view [44, 52]. With one run per system we can only measure the second part. Table 1 says which part each of our procedures handles. Inflation from development and the randomness of an agent from one run to the next are not modelled; both push reported scores up, so a winner may be more inflated than our correction removes. Section 6 puts a number on one form of development inflation, reporting the best of several runs, using the Terminal-Bench submissions that ran the whole benchmark more than once.

Where a reported score can be wrong	What handles it here	Status
Luck in which tasks were drawn	paired tests, rank intervals, set of possible best systems, resolution, winner correction	modelled
The agent giving different answers from one run to the next	nothing (single runs); measured on Terminal-Bench from its five runs per task	not modelled
Development: versions tried, tuning and training on the public tasks	nothing; the effect of reporting the best of several runs is bounded from Terminal-Bench's repeated runs	not modelled

Table 1: What the procedures in this paper handle, and what they do not.

3 Methods

Record test. Let a be the record holder and b a new submission with a higher score, $\widehat{p}_b > \widehat{p}_a$. Tasks that both solved or both failed tell us nothing about which is better, so we look only at the tasks where they disagree: n_b tasks solved only by b and n_a solved only by a, with $n = n_a + n_b$ in total. If the two systems were equally good, each of these n tasks would be a coin flip, so the natural test asks whether n_b wins out of n is more than a fair coin would give. This is the binomial (sign) test, the exact form of McNemar's test [33]. There is a catch: we only look at this step *because* b won more of the disputed tasks ($n_b > n_a$), and that alone makes the count look impressive. So we run the test given that fact: with $X \sim \mathrm{Bin}(n, \frac{1}{2})$ the number of heads in n fair coin flips, the

selective p-value is

$$p_{\text{sel}} = P(X \geq n_b \mid X > n/2) = \frac{P(X \geq n_b)}{P(X > n/2)}.$$

In words: among all the ways a fair coin could have given b the majority, how often would it have given b at least this many wins? A p-value is the chance of seeing a result at least this extreme if the two systems were really equal; a small one (we use 0.05, one in twenty) means luck is an unlikely explanation. If the holder were fixed in advance and the null held (on each disputed task b is no likelier than a to be the one that passes), p_{sel} would be a valid p-value exactly; Proposition 1 below shows it stays valid when the holder is itself the best of everything before it. For odd n it equals the usual two-sided exact p-value. For even n it is larger, because $P(X > n/2) = \{1 - P(X = n/2)\}/2 < \frac{1}{2}$: the two-sided test then rejects too often among record steps (with $n = 44$ its conditional size is 5.5%), and a one-sided test at level α rejects about 2α of them. We call a step significant when $p_{\text{sel}} \leq 0.05$; the two-sided and one-sided tests at 5% are reported as sensitivity checks. Section 5 checks by simulation that the test rejects no more than 5% of true-null steps, under two nulls and by the step's position in the chain, and repeats the test on split halves of the real boards. When a board has many record steps, some will pass at 5% by chance; Holm's correction [18] raises the bar so that the chance of *any* false pass on one board stays at 5%. For Terminal-Bench, where each y_{kt} is a rate rather than a pass or fail, we use the sign-flip version: randomly flip the sign of each task's difference many times (20,000 draws) and compute $P(S \geq s_{\text{obs}} \mid S > 0)$ for the sum S; this one is approximate. Tasks from the same code repository are not independent (an agent that handles one repository well tends to handle its other tasks well too), so the task-level test is the optimistic one and the repository-level test below the cautious one; Section 5 measures the difference.

Submissions sharing a date. Under the best-first ordering (described below) the challenger at a record step is the best of all submissions that share its date. That is a second kind of selection the record event does not cover: in a simulation where no system is better than any other and 20 submissions share a date, the per-step test rejects about 10% of record steps instead of 5%. We therefore multiply the p-value of a record step by g, the number of submissions on the challenger's date, the standard Bonferroni fix for picking the best of g (the package's tests include that simulation); a submission with a date of its own has $g = 1$. On the real boards 19 of the 74 record steps have g between 2 and 4; without the correction 20 steps are significant, with it 20.

Repository-level record test. For boards that label each task with its code repository we also run a repository-level test: add up the per-task differences within each repository, then randomly flip the sign of each repository total (all 2^G patterns when there are $G \leq 14$ repositories). Its selective form conditions on a positive sum in the same way. It is valid as long as the repository totals are equally likely to be positive or negative under the null; with only a dozen repositories it has little power, which is why the task-level count stays the headline and the repository-level count sits beside it as the cautious one.

Ordering submissions that share a date. Which steps count as records depends on how we order submissions with the same date. The main analysis orders them best first: this gives the fewest and biggest steps, never invents a record that was not on the leaderboard, and is the most generous reading for the board. We also report worst first, which gives the most steps but can create records that never actually appeared, so we treat it only as a bound. The best-first challenger is the best of its date, which is the selection the per-date factor above corrects for.

Certifying records as they arrive. A leaderboard has to decide about each record when it comes in, without knowing how many records will follow, so Holm over the finished chain is only something you can do looking back. We give a procedure for the live setting. For the i-th record step, with holder a and challenger b, let $p_i = p_{\mathrm{sel}}$ be the selective p-value of the record test. With a fixed holder it is a valid p-value given that the step is a record, because the record event is exactly $\{X > n/2\}$. A holder that is the best so far got there partly by luck, so its results are tilted upward; this works in our favour, making p_i if anything too cautious, and we can prove it rather than just simulate it.

> **Proposition 1.** Let the outcome vectors of the K systems be independent across tasks, and let the *conditional task-wise dominance null* hold: for each task, given the task and the outcomes of every system other than a and b (earlier and later), the probability that b passes and a fails is at most the probability that a passes and b fails. (Equality is the null of the exact test, no task-level advantage for b; the null implies $\theta_b \le \theta_a$ but is not implied by it.) Let A be any event that does not involve the outcomes of b and that, given the outcomes of the other systems, is increasing in the outcomes of a task by task; the event that a holds the record among the earlier submissions, which depends on a only through its total, is one. Then, conditional on A, on the record event $\{n_b > n_a\}$, on the discordant set and on the outcomes outside it, $P(p_i \le u) \le u$ for every $u \in [0, 1]$.

In plain terms: the proposition says that knowing the holder is "the best so far" (or anything else that only gets more likely as the holder does better) can only make the p-value more cautious, never less. The proof has three steps: under the null the challenger's win count on the disputed tasks behaves like at most a fair coin; knowing the holder did well pushes that count further down; and a count pushed down gives a larger p-value.

Proof. Fix the discordant set D with $|D| = n$, the outcomes of a and b outside D and the outcomes of every other system. By independence across tasks, given these the n tasks of D are independently b-only with probabilities at most one half, so the law of n_b is dominated in the likelihood-ratio order by $\mathrm{Bin}(n, \frac{1}{2})$: Bernoulli laws are log-concave, and the likelihood-ratio order is preserved under convolution of log-concave laws [43, Section 1.C]. Within D, a passes exactly the tasks that are not b-only, so A is a decreasing event in the vector of b-only indicators, and by Efron's monotonicity theorem for independent variables with log-concave laws [9], $P(A \mid n_b = k, \dots) = g(k)$ is a decreasing function of k (for the event that a holds the record, an indicator of $\{k \le \text{constant}\}$). Conditioning on A multiplies the law of n_b by g, which moves it downward in the likelihood-ratio order; conditioning further on $\{n_b > n/2\}$ restricts both laws to the same set and preserves the order. Hence $n_b \mid A, \{n_b > n/2\}$ is stochastically at most $X \mid \{X > n/2\}$ with $X \sim \mathrm{Bin}(n, \frac{1}{2})$; p_i is a decreasing function of n_b, so $P(p_i \le u) \le P\{p(X) \le u \mid X > n/2\} \le u$. □

The bound is exact at the levels the discrete p-value can actually take when the null holds with equality, and cautious otherwise. We also check the proposition by brute force in the package's tests: on small boards we list every possible outcome, separately for each number of disputed tasks, for holder events that do and do not depend only on the total, including "the holder was certified and a later challenger arrived", and we include events that go the wrong way as negative controls, which must break the bound and do. The proposition also covers the certified baseline, through a simple monotonicity property of the selective p-value.

> **Lemma 1.** p_{sel} decreases when a task won by the challenger is added to the discordant set and increases when a task won by the holder is added.

In words: more wins for the challenger make the step look stronger, more wins for the holder make it look weaker, which is what one would hope. The proof is a short Pascal-rule computation

(Appendix D). Whether a was certified against its own reference, and whether no later submission has been certified against a, both depend on a's outcomes only through counts of this kind, so by Lemma 1 the event "a is the certified holder when b arrives" is increasing in a's outcomes given the other systems, and Proposition 1 applies to it.

So the proposition covers both baselines: the leaderboard holder, which is simply the best so far, and the certified holder, which earned its place by passing an earlier test. Its null is the conditional task-wise dominance null, which asks more than $\theta_b \le \theta_a$: when b is a tweaked copy of an earlier system c, b is likelier than a to pass exactly where c passed, the per-task probabilities sit on both sides of one half, and the proof says nothing, although every record may still be luck. A rejection is therefore evidence against a dominating b task by task, the same reading as for McNemar's test; validity under the weaker null $\theta_b \le \theta_a$ alone is not proved, and Section 5 simulates the case where the two differ. How strict the test is at the i-th record (its level α_i) is set by one of three rules. *Alpha-spending:* $\alpha_i = 6\alpha/(\pi^2 i^2)$, so that $\sum_i \alpha_i = \alpha$. Think of α as a budget of allowed error, 5% in all, handed out in shrinking pieces to the records as they arrive: the first record gets about 61% of it, the second about 15%, and so on, so the pieces never add up to more than the budget. Its guarantee follows from Proposition 1 and the union bound (the chance that at least one of several things happens is at most the sum of their chances), with no independence assumed.

> **Corollary 1.** Let the conditions of Proposition 1 hold for every pair that forms a record step on the leaderboard baseline, and let the i-th record step be tested at level α_i with $\sum_i \alpha_i \le \alpha$. Then the probability that some record step at which the conditional task-wise dominance null holds is certified is at most α, whatever the number of submissions, their order and the dependence between steps.

In words: hand out the error budget in pieces that add up to α, and the chance that any false record is ever certified is at most α, however long the chain gets and however the steps depend on one another. *Proof.* Take first a submission order that does not depend on outcomes (distinct dates). Let $E_i(a, b)$ be the event that the i-th record step has holder a and challenger b. It is the intersection of the record event $\{n_b > n_a\}$ with an event that does not involve b, depends on the outcomes of a only through its total score and is increasing in it: a scored higher than every submission before it, no submission between a and b scored higher than a, and the number of record steps before a, which is determined by the submissions before a, is $i - 1$. Proposition 1 applies with A that event, so $P(p_i \le \alpha_i \mid E_i(a, b), \ldots) \le \alpha_i$ whenever the null holds for (a, b); summing over the disjoint events $E_i(a, b)$ gives $P(\text{a null pair is certified at step } i) \le \alpha_i$, and the union bound over i gives the result. Under the best-first ordering the challenger is the best of the g submissions on its date, and the set of submissions between a and b depends on b's score; the per-date correction removes both: each member d of the date is tested, if at all, at level α_i/g against an event A that involves only submissions of earlier dates, so the union bound over the members gives $P(\text{a null pair from that date is certified}) \le \alpha_i$, and each index i is used by exactly one date because a date whose best member beats the holder is a record step whether or not it is certified. □

Corollary 1 needs two things to be settled before the challenger's results are looked at: the level used at step i and the event that put the holder in place. Both hold for the leaderboard baseline, because how many records came before a is decided by the submissions before a. For the certified baseline, how many tests came before a challenger depends on how many submissions beat the certified holder, which depends on the holder's own results, so levels that count tests are not settled in this sense; levels that count calendar dates since the holder arrived are.

Corollary 3. Under the conditions of Proposition 1 for every tested pair, the certified-baseline procedure with the tenure-indexed levels $\alpha_{j,m} = \alpha\gamma_j\gamma_m$, where j is one plus the number of certifications so far and m the number of distinct submission dates since the certified holder's date, has a super-uniform p-value at every test and certifies some null pair with probability at most α, for any dependence.

In words: on the certified baseline, set the level from two counters that the challenger's results cannot touch, how many certifications have happened and how many dates have passed since the certified holder arrived; the whole-chain guarantee then holds. *Proof.* With these levels the event that a is the certified holder when b arrives, that a was certified against its own reference and that no later submission has been certified against a, involves a only through counts of the kind in Lemma 1 at levels fixed by the calendar, so it is increasing in a's outcomes and does not involve b; Proposition 1 gives per-step validity. Given the conditioning, j is determined by the submissions before the holder together with the holder event, and m by the calendar, so the level is fixed; each pair (j, m) is used by at most one date, the per-date correction handles the members of that date as in Corollary 1, and the levels used over any realised chain sum to at most $\alpha \sum_j \gamma_j \sum_m \gamma_m \leq \alpha$. □

The tenure rule spends a little budget on every date since the holder arrived, whether or not anything was tested that day, which costs power on long chains. The spending and fallback rules that count tests instead have no such proof on the certified baseline, per step or over the chain, because the number of tests carries information about the holder's score; they are checked by simulation only.

Online fallback: $\alpha_i = 6\alpha/(\pi^2 i^2) + \alpha_{i-1}\,\mathbf{1}\{\text{record } i-1 \text{ was certified}\}$. In words: a record that passes hands its unused level on to the next record, so a run of genuine records builds up budget, as in the fixed-sequence fallback procedure [51] and its online form [48]; the rule is never stricter than alpha-spending at any step and keeps the same guarantee.

Corollary 2. Under the conditions of Corollary 1, the online fallback rule certifies some record step at which the conditional task-wise dominance null holds with probability at most α.

In words: a false record can only inherit budget from genuine records just before it, and each genuine record's budget can be inherited only once, so the total budget a false record could ever use still adds up to at most α. *Proof.* Let step i be the first null step certified. Every step in the run of consecutive certified steps ending at $i-1$ is then non-null, so the level used at i is at most $L_i = \alpha \sum_{k \in R_i} \gamma_k$, with $\gamma_k = 6/(\pi^2 k^2)$ and R_i the maximal run of non-null steps immediately before i together with i itself. R_i is determined by the identities of the earlier pairs, which are fixed by the conditioning of Proposition 1 on $E_i(a, b)$ and the earlier submissions, so Proposition 1 gives $P(\text{step } i \text{ is the first null step certified}) \leq \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{1}\{\text{step } i \text{ is null}\}\, L_i]$. The runs R_i of distinct null steps are disjoint, so $\sum_{i \text{ null}} L_i \leq \alpha \sum_k \gamma_k = \alpha$ on every realisation of the chain, and summing over i gives the result. □ *LORD++* [41]: an online false-discovery-rate rule, which controls the expected share of certified records that are false rather than the chance of any false one, with level $\alpha_i = \gamma_i W_0 + (\alpha - W_0)\gamma_{i-\tau_1} + \alpha \sum_{j \geq 2} \gamma_{i-\tau_j}$, where τ_j is the index of the j-th certified record, $W_0 = \alpha/2$, and γ_j is any sequence with $\sum_j \gamma_j \leq 1$; we use $\gamma_j = 6/(\pi^2 j^2)$, the same sequence as the spending rule, because the sequence published with LORD++ is built for streams of thousands of tests and leaves almost no budget for a chain of thirty records. Each certified record earns budget back, so late records stay testable; LORD++ starts with half the spending rule's budget and overtakes it once records are certified. Its guarantee is proved for independent p-values, and ours

Procedure	Baseline	Guarantee	Where
Selective record test (with the per-date factor)	either	exact size given the record event under the conditional task-wise dominance null, tasks independent; conservative when the holder is a running maximum or a certified holder	Prop. 1, Lemma 1
Alpha-spending	leaderboard	family-wise error $\leq \alpha$ over the chain, any dependence	Cor. 1
Online fallback	leaderboard	the same, with a level never below spending's	Cor. 2
Tenure-indexed spending	certified	family-wise error $\leq \alpha$ over the chain, any dependence	Cor. 3
Spending, fallback	certified	none (the test count depends on the holder's outcomes); by simulation	Sec. 5
LORD++	either	false-discovery rate proved for independent p-values; dependent here, by simulation	Sec. 5
Holm over the realised chain	leaderboard	retrospective, adaptive family; by simulation	Sec. 5
Polyhedral p-value	leaderboard	none; continuity-corrected, by simulation	App. E
Hybrid and zoom intervals	–	coverage under normality with known covariance	Sec. 3
Iterated bootstrap	–	none; by simulation and held-out tasks	Sec. 5
Confidence set of the best	–	retains a truly best system at about the nominal rate; by simulation	Sec. 5

Table 2: What is proved and what is simulated, for every procedure in the paper.

share tasks: alpha-spending and online fallback are the rules with the guarantee, and LORD++ is an alternative checked by simulation; Javanmard and Montanari [23] give a more cautious variant for dependent p-values, which we have not implemented. There are two choices for what to test against: each leaderboard record against the record it replaced, or every submission that beats the last *certified* record against that record, so that the certified leader only changes when a record is certified, as in the Ladder [4]; Corollary 3 covers the second. A normal-theory alternative that accounts for both selections at once (the polyhedral lemma applied to the event that b is a record and a was the holder) is described in Appendix E; it needs a continuity correction on discrete scores and has no finite-sample guarantee, so it is reported only as a comparison. Table 2 lists, for every procedure in the paper, what is proved and what rests on simulation.

Lag. For each record we ask how far back in the chain of records one must go before the new record is clearly better than that older record (same test, no correction). A lag of one means the record is clearly better than the one it replaced; a lag of three means it is clearly better than the record three steps back but not the two in between.

Resolution. Resolution means the smallest true gap a benchmark can reliably see. Let s be the typical (median) standard deviation of the per-task differences between systems next to each other in the ranking, among the ten highest-scoring systems. With $z = \Phi^{-1}(0.975) + \Phi^{-1}(0.80)$, the paired test at level 0.05 (two-sided; the selective record test has the same threshold up to the even-n correction) detects a true gap of $\mathrm{MDD} = z\,s/\sqrt{T}$ (the minimum detectable difference) with 80% power, meaning it will catch a gap that size four times out of five, and catching a gap Δ with that power takes $(zs/\Delta)^2$ tasks. Redrawing the tasks with a bootstrap gives an interval for both

numbers. The smallest margin the test will call significant for a typical pair is about $1.96\,s/\sqrt{T}$, roughly 0.7 of the MDD. This is a normal approximation [6, 27]; Section 5 checks it by simulation.

Rank intervals and top-rank frequency. We redraw the tasks with replacement many times, recompute every score and rank each time (tied systems share the better rank), and report the range that holds the middle 95% of each system's ranks. The top-rank frequency of a system is the share of redraws in which it has the top score, with ties split equally. It is a frequency across redraws of the tasks, not the probability that the system is best. Section 5 shows that the intervals contain the true rank when the true gaps are as big as the observed ones, but not when the leaders are truly tied, so the set below is the right statement to make about who could be best.

Set of possible best systems (confidence set of the best). Following multiple comparisons with the best [19], as adapted to paired bootstraps by Jain [22], we keep every system that no rival beats by more than a margin set to cover all comparisons at once. Let $\widehat{s}_{ij}$ be the standard error of $\widehat{p}_j - \widehat{p}_i$ from $\widehat{\Sigma}$ and $\widehat{p}^*$ scores from one redraw of the tasks. For each system i let $M_i = \max_{j \neq i}\{(\widehat{p}^*_j - \widehat{p}^*_i) - (\widehat{p}_j - \widehat{p}_i)\}/\widehat{s}_{ij}$, the furthest any rival moves ahead of i in a redraw, in standard-error units. System i stays in the set if $\widehat{p}_j - \widehat{p}_i \leq c\,\widehat{s}_{ij}$ for all j, with c the largest over i of the $(1-\alpha)$ quantile of M_i. A system that is truly best then stays in the set about $1-\alpha$ of the time, which is all the set promises; an earlier draft used the quantile of $\max_i M_i$, an all-pairs bound that gives larger sets, and we report both. The guarantee is approximate and holds only for large samples, and in our simulations the set is on the cautious side. The set says who cannot be ruled out, not who is likely to be best.

The winner's curse. Let $w = \arg\max_k \widehat{p}_k$ be the system with the top score. Its reported score $\widehat{p}_w$ is too high on average, because w was picked for having the highest score and part of a highest score is good luck. This is the winner's curse. We consider two corrections.

Conditional (polyhedral) method. Treat the scores as normal, $\widehat{p} \sim N(\theta, \widehat{\Sigma})$, with $\widehat{\Sigma}$ known. The event that w wins is $\{\widehat{p}_j - \widehat{p}_w \leq 0,\ j \neq w\}$. By the polyhedral lemma [13, 29], given this event and the part of $\widehat{p}$ unrelated to $\widehat{p}_w$, the winner's score follows a normal distribution with mean θ_w and variance Σ_{ww} cut off to an interval $[V^-, V^+]$ whose ends depend only on the other systems' scores and on $\widehat{\Sigma}$. Inverting that cut-off normal distribution gives a median-unbiased estimate and a confidence interval for θ_w that remain valid after the winner was picked. It is exact under normality, but it breaks down when the winner ties its runner-up, and nearly so when the margin is small, because the observed score then sits right at the edge of the cut-off and the interval runs off to infinity; two of our six real boards have an exact tie at the top.

Baselines. Two published corrections run alongside ours. The hybrid of Andrews et al. [1] fixes the runaway-interval problem by first drawing a wide interval that covers every system's true score at once with confidence $1-\beta$, and then applying the conditional method inside that interval; the result can never run off to infinity, and the conditional level is adjusted to $(\alpha-\beta)/(1-\beta)$ so that overall coverage is still at least $1-\alpha$. Its estimate is median-unbiased under the hybrid distribution. We use $\beta = \alpha/10$. The zoom correction of Zrnic and Fithian [56], in its simplest, locally simultaneous form [55], works in two stages: spend a share ν of the error budget on intervals for every system that all hold at once, keep the systems that could plausibly be the winner (those whose upper limit reaches the highest lower limit), then spend the remaining $\alpha - \nu$ on a joint interval over that smaller set alone; it corrects the interval, not the point estimate, and we use $\nu = \alpha/10$. Both are exact when the scores are normal with known covariance; the joint quantiles are computed by Monte Carlo from $\widehat{\Sigma}$. Hoff and Tokdar [17] is not implemented.

Iterated bootstrap. The bootstrap builds a pretend world in which the observed scores are the truth, by redrawing the tasks with replacement. In that world we know every system's true score, so we can measure directly how much a winner's score is inflated by being the winner. Draw a task resample, let w^* be its winner, and set $\Delta^* = \widehat{p}^*_{w^*} - \widehat{p}_{w^*}$, how far the pretend winner beat its own pretend truth. The plug-in correction is $\widehat{p}_w - \widehat{b}_1$ with $\widehat{b}_1 = \mathbb{E}^*\Delta^*$, the average of that gap [11, 12]. It does not remove all the bias, because the observed scores of the leaders are more spread out than their true scores, so being the winner is a smaller achievement in the pretend world than in reality. A second round of bootstrap, run inside each resample, estimates the bias that remains: $\widehat{\theta}_w = \widehat{p}_w - 2\widehat{b}_1 + \mathbb{E}^*\widehat{b}^*_1$, where $\widehat{b}^*_1$ is the plug-in bias computed from each outer resample. The interval is $\widehat{\theta}_w$ minus the quantiles of the centred Δ^*. It works for ties and when repositories rather than tasks are resampled. Neither correction comes with a general theory here: the conditional method is exact only when the scores are normal with known covariance, and the iterated bootstrap is justified by how well it does in Section 5, not by a theorem; taking a maximum is not a smooth operation, so the bootstrap is not guaranteed to work near ties.

4 Data

We use the task-by-task results that the leaderboards themselves publish. For SWE-bench [24, 39, 45, 53] we use the submission records in the public `experiments` repository [46]: for each submission, the list of tasks it solved, matched against the official task list so that tasks nobody solved are counted too. Verified has 135 usable submissions out of 182 on 500 tasks; Lite has 84 on 300, Test 24 on 2,294, Multimodal 12 on 510, and Multilingual 14 on 300. Each submission is one run, dated by the date in its folder name; 11 of the 14 Multilingual submissions share one date, so which steps count as records there depends on the ordering rule, and under our main rule it has none. Two Verified submissions tie exactly for first (396 of 500 tasks, disagreeing on 36 tasks), and two Multimodal submissions tie for first; we name both and call the one that ranks first more often across redraws the leader.

The 47 Verified submissions with no task-by-task file are dated 2025-07 to 2026-02 and report only an overall score. Their median score is 61.0% against 53.2% for the submissions we could use, so they are not a random sample of the board. Their highest score is 76.8%, below the record of 79.2%, and by overall score none of them would ever have held the record: the chain built from all 182 submissions has the same 30 steps. So none of them could have been the record that one of our tested records replaced, but they are missing from the ranks, from the set of possible best systems and from the pool the winner was picked from, and we do not know which tasks they solved.

For Terminal-Bench 2 [34, 47] we use the result file of each job in the leaderboard dataset. Every run (trial) named in a file is counted once: runs listed with reward 1 pass, runs listed with reward 0 fail, and runs that appear only in the error lists (agent errors, timeouts) count as failures. The per-task score is the share of that task's runs that passed. Of 75 submissions, 2 whose job files hold no per-task results, 1 with a job labelled as benchmark version 2.1 and 5 with missing tasks or dates are dropped, leaving 67 on 89 tasks. The leaderboard is meant to run five trials per task, but 26 submissions pool several jobs, and across the kept submissions the number of runs on a task ranges from 1 to 10; 60 submissions have exactly five everywhere. Most job files do not say which benchmark version they ran; we trust the dataset's folder (the 2.0 leaderboard).

For the comparison with a leaderboard of plain language models rather than agents we use LiveBench [50], which scores each question automatically, from the per-question file the leaderboard is computed from (the `livebench/model_judgment` dataset, April 2025 version: 195 models and 494 questions in three categories, coding, instruction following and language). Its questions change

over time, so different models were judged on different sets; we keep the 318 questions that at least half of the models answered and the 94 models that answered every one of them (101 dropped, most of them partial re-judgings), average the 571 cases where one model was judged twice on one question, and date a model by its earliest judgment in the file, from 2024-06 to 2025-03; 8 models share the first date. Scores are credit between 0 and 1, 77% of them exactly 0 or 1, and for the grouped test the groups are its 6 task types. The data and code to rebuild every board are in the project repository.

5 Validation

5.1 Does the record test reject as often as it claims?

A test at the 5% level should wrongly call a lucky record "clearly better" no more than 5% of the time. We check this on fake boards built to look like SWE-bench Verified: each task gets a difficulty from the real pass rates of the 30 strongest systems (standard deviation 2.40 on the logit scale), system k passes task t with probability $\text{sigmoid}(a_k + L_t)$, and the outcomes of different systems on the same task are linked through a Gaussian copula with correlation $\rho = 0.29$, tuned so that the task-by-task spread between two equally able systems (0.34) matches the real board (0.34); real systems share base models and scaffolding, so they agree on far more tasks than shared difficulty alone would give. Two kinds of "nothing is really better" world are simulated (Table 6). In the *global null*, 40 equally able systems arrive one after another, so every record is luck and the holder is always the luckiest so far (600 boards per size). In the *selected-step null*, holder and challenger are equally able and the holder is not inflated; we keep the pairs in which the challenger scored higher (20,000 pairs per size), which is the record condition. At 500 tasks the one-sided test at 5% wrongly rejects 8.0% of selected steps, close to the 2α predicted above, the two-sided test 3.9% and the selective test 3.7%. Under the global null the selective test's rate is 0.5% averaged over the chain, but the average hides where in the chain the step is: the first step, where the holder is simply the first submission and so only mildly lucky, rejects 4.0% one-sided and 1.0% selective, and later steps, against a holder that is the luckiest of many, almost never (Table 16). The selective test is at or below 5% given the record event by construction, and the simulation agrees in every case, also with the model fitted to Lite, Terminal-Bench and LiveBench (Appendix C); the two-sided test differs from it only through the even-n effect, and the one-sided test rejects too often. The chance that Holm wrongly passes at least one step on a global-null board is 0.7%. A second simulation checks the resolution formula: at the formula's minimum detectable difference, the selective test catches the gap 0.78 of the time at 500 tasks (Table 17), against a target of 0.80.

A split-half check on the real boards asks whether the test actually separates genuine records from lucky ones (Table 3). For every record step we split the tasks into two random halves 200 times, run the test on one half, and record whether the challenger still beats the holder on the other half. Steps that pass on the first half (19% of splits, against 3% under the pure-luck reference below) beat the holder on the second half 0.92 of the time and pass the test there 0.67 of the time, against 0.79 and 0.08 for steps that did not pass on the first half. Those raw figures need a reference point: every step is a record on the full data, so a challenger that did well on one half must have done less well on the other, and even a pure-luck record beats the holder on the second half more often than not. We therefore simulate that pure-luck reference for each step with its own number of disputed tasks (fair-coin signs, conditioned on the record event on the full data, then the same split): it gives 0.47 for first halves that pass and 0.74 for those that do not. Steps that pass repeat far above that reference, and steps that do not pass repeat at about it, on every board, which is what a test that separates genuine records from lucky ones should produce; the pooled figures are

Board	Steps	Half 1 significant			Half 1 not significant		
		share of splits	replicates	null reference	share of splits	replicates	null reference
SWE-bench Verified	30	10%	0.85	0.48	90%	0.76	0.74
SWE-bench Lite	15	13%	0.87	0.45	87%	0.78	0.73
SWE-bench Test	13	63%	0.99	0.49	37%	0.88	0.75
SWE-bench Multimodal	7	5%	0.71	0.47	95%	0.80	0.73
Terminal-Bench 2	9	11%	0.78	0.43	89%	0.80	0.73
All boards	74	19%	0.92	0.47	81%	0.79	0.74

Table 3: Split-half check of the record test on the real boards, 200 random halves per record step. Share of splits: how often the test on half 1 passes. Replicates: share of those splits in which the challenger still beats the holder on half 2. Null reference: the same quantity simulated for each step with its own number of disputed tasks under fair-coin signs, conditioned on the record event on the full data.

dominated by SWE-bench Test, and Multimodal and Terminal-Bench contribute few passing splits.

Tasks from the same code repository move together, and the task-level test treats them as if they were independent. Table 5 simulates the selected-step null with a system-by-repository effect on Verified's own 12 repositories, one of which holds 231 of the 500 tasks: each system gets a random shift $u_{kg} \sim N(0, \tau^2)$ to its logit in repository g, on top of the shared difficulty and the copula, so a system can be especially good or bad at one repository. At $\tau = 0.25$ the task-level selective test wrongly rejects 9.6% of null record steps and at $\tau = 0.5$ 24.9%, while the repository-level test stays at 3.1% and 3.4%. The data do not say exactly how big τ is. A direct estimate from the per-repository residuals of the 30 strongest systems is zero, but the typical ratio of the repository-level to the task-level standard error for neighbouring top-10 pairs on the real board is 1.13, against 0.88 if tasks were independent with these repository sizes (the repository-level estimator comes out too small when one repository dominates) and 1.01 and 1.32 at $\tau = 0.25$ and 0.5, which points to a τ in that range. So the task-level counts are optimistic where repositories matter, by an amount the data leave uncertain, and the repository-level counts in Section 6 are the cautious ones.

Tuning on the public tasks is outside our model, but its simplest form can be priced (Table 4). Suppose a team tries V equally able versions of its system on the benchmark and submits only the best one. The record test allows for one challenger having scored higher, not for the best of V, so under the selected-step null it wrongly rejects 4.9% of record steps at $V = 2$, 8.2% at $V = 5$ and 12.4% at $V = 10$, and the share of submissions that set a record rises from 48% to 90%. If the team declares V, multiplying the p-value by V (the Bonferroni correction, $\min(1, Vp_{\text{sel}})$) restores the level (1.8% at $V = 5$, 1.5% at $V = 10$); an exact test for the best of V would need the task-by-task results of all V versions, which a leaderboard never sees, so when only V is declared the Bonferroni correction is what is available. On a chain in which every submission is the best of V, the holder is inflated in the same way and the chance of any false certification falls to 0.0% at $V = 10$; the danger is one team trying many versions against a holder that did not. This is why our reporting checklist asks for the number of versions tried: without it the true level of the record test is unknown.

5.2 Do the certification rules keep their promise?

We simulate boards of 40 submissions on 500 tasks from the fitted model (300 boards per scenario; Table 7). Under the global null every record is luck. In the staircase scenario the true score rises by 3 points every 5 submissions, so records are a mix of genuine jumps and lucky steps within a level; in the late scenario one genuine jump of twice that size happens halfway through the chain. A certified step counts as false if the new system's true score is not higher than that of

		Selected-step null		Global null, chain of 40	
V	sets a record	size, selective	size, V-corrected	FWER, selective	FWER, V-corrected
1	48%	3.5%	3.5%	2.5%	2.5%
2	64%	4.9%	2.5%	1.0%	0.0%
3	73%	6.7%	2.1%	0.0%	0.0%
5	81%	8.2%	1.8%	0.0%	0.0%
10	90%	12.4%	1.5%	0.0%	0.0%

Table 4: The record test when the submission is the best of V equally able private tries on the same tasks (fitted Verified model, 500 tasks). Selected-step null: share of submissions that set a record, and how often the selective test and the V-corrected test wrongly reject among them. Global null: false certifications per board on 40-submission chains in which every submission is the best of V.

τ (logit)	Task-level selective test	Repository-level test	SE ratio, repository / task
0.00	3.8%	2.5%	0.88
0.25	9.6%	3.1%	1.01
0.50	24.9%	3.4%	1.32
1.00	49.4%	3.7%	2.08

Table 5: False-rejection rate of the record test when systems have repository-specific strengths (τ on the logit scale): selected-step null on Verified's repositories, 20,000 pairs per level. SE ratio: mean ratio of the repository-level to the task-level standard error of the paired difference; the real board's median for neighbouring top-10 pairs is 1.13.

the system it was tested against. Under the global null the unadjusted test certifies a false record on 5% of boards, Holm over the finished chain on 3%, alpha-spending on 3%, online fallback on 3%, LORD++ on 2%, and the continuity-corrected polyhedral p-value under alpha-spending on 3%; all stay under 5%. With one late jump of twice the step size, the share of genuine records certified is 14% for Holm, 9% for alpha-spending, 9% for online fallback, 5% for LORD++ and 12% for the polyhedral p-value under alpha-spending, with 0%, 1%, 1%, 1% and 2% of the certified records being false; the unadjusted test certifies 36% of genuine records, but 6% of what it certifies is false. The staircase's jumps of 3 points sit right at the limit of what a 500-task board can see, and no rule with error control certifies more than 1% of them (the unadjusted test certifies 10%); testing every submission that beats the last certified record, instead of only leaderboard records, raises the number of tests to 28.8 per board and the share certified to 11%, with 0% of certifications false. Online fallback matches alpha-spending in every scenario here, because genuine records never arrive in runs big enough to see, and by construction it never does worse; it pays off only where several records in a row are genuine and large, which none of the real boards below shows. On the certified baseline, where every submission above the last certified record is tested, the tenure rule of Corollary 3 certifies a false record on 3% of global-null boards and test-counting alpha-spending on 4%; on the staircase they certify 8% and 9% of genuine steps, and with one late jump 4% and 11%, the price of spending budget on dates with no test. In the variant scenario every submission is equally able, but 50% of the submissions after the first are tweaked copies of a random earlier submission (its results with passes flipped to failures at 10% and failures flipped to passes at the rate that keeps the true score the same), the case where the task-level null of Proposition 1 fails even though every record is still luck: the unadjusted test certifies a false record on 4% of boards, Holm on 1%, alpha-spending on 1% and LORD++ on 0%, so the rules stay at or below their level there too. Alpha-spending has the stronger guarantee; LORD++ starts with half the budget and

Tasks	Steps per board	Global null (holder is a running maximum) selective	two-sided	one-sided	Selected-step null (holder not inflated) selective	two-sided	one-sided	Holm, any rejection (selective)
300	2.8	0.3%	0.3%	1.4%	3.7%	3.8%	8.2%	0.7%
500	2.8	0.5%	0.5%	1.7%	3.7%	3.9%	8.0%	0.7%
2,000	3.0	0.8%	0.8%	2.0%	4.4%	4.5%	9.1%	0.7%

Table 6: How often the record test wrongly rejects among record steps, simulated from the fitted Verified model. Global null: 40 equally able systems in sequence, averaged over the chain. Selected-step null: equally able holder and challenger, challenger scored higher. A correct test rejects 5% at the 5% level.

Procedure	Global null FWER	certified	Staircase FDR	power	certified	One late jump FDR	power	certified	Variants, global null FWER	certified
unadjusted, exact	4.7%	0.05	5.4%	10%	0.7	5.7%	36%	0.42	4.0%	0.04
Holm over the realised chain	3.0%	0.03	0.0%	1%	0.1	0.3%	14%	0.14	1.0%	0.01
alpha-spending, exact	2.7%	0.03	0.3%	0%	0.0	1.3%	9%	0.10	1.3%	0.01
online fallback, exact	2.7%	0.03	0.3%	0%	0.0	1.3%	9%	0.10	1.3%	0.01
LORD++, exact	1.7%	0.02	0.0%	0%	0.0	1.0%	5%	0.06	0.0%	0.00
alpha-spending, polyhedral	3.3%	0.03	0.3%	1%	0.0	2.0%	12%	0.14	3.3%	0.03
LORD++, polyhedral	2.0%	0.02	0.0%	0%	0.0	1.0%	8%	0.09	0.0%	0.00
LORD++, exact, certified baseline	2.3%	0.02	0.1%	11%	2.7	1.0%	8%	0.71	0.7%	0.01
alpha-spending, exact, certified baseline	4.0%	0.04	0.1%	9%	2.4	1.3%	11%	0.81	1.7%	0.02
tenure-indexed spending, exact, certified baseline	3.0%	0.03	0.0%	8%	2.2	1.3%	4%	0.54	0.7%	0.01

Table 7: Certification rules on simulated 40-submission boards of 500 tasks (fitted Verified model). FWER: share of boards with at least one false certification. FDR: expected share of certified records that are false. Power: share of genuine record steps certified. Certified: mean number of certified records per board.

earns budget back on each certification, so it does worse when the only genuine record comes early and better on chains with several genuine jumps, as on the real boards below.

5.3 Does the winner's-curse correction work?

We test the corrections on SWE-bench Verified, with Lite and Terminal-Bench as further checks, in four settings. **Known truth.** We treat the real table of results as the whole population, draw a pretend "benchmark" of n tasks from it with replacement, and compare each estimate with the winner's true score on the whole population. This favours a bootstrap method, because the true gaps between systems equal the observed gaps. **Equal leaders.** The hardest case: the top 20 systems are given exactly the same true ability, outcomes are simulated from the fitted task-difficulty model, and the truth is known. **Held-out tasks.** The real 500 tasks are split at random into two halves; the winner is picked on the first half and the estimate is compared with its score on the second half, which is a fair but noisy stand-in for the truth. **Held-out repositories.** The same, but the halves are made of different repositories, chosen among the 504 repository subsets that put 40 to 60% of the tasks in the selection half (200 to 300 tasks). The selection board keeps its repository labels and the corrections resample repositories. The validation score is adjusted for the average difference in difficulty between the halves across all systems; the appendix reports the unadjusted target and the task-resampling corrections as well. Alongside our two corrections we run the hybrid and zoom baselines of Section 3. Table 8 gives the mean error with its simulation standard error, the median error, the root mean squared error, how often the 95% interval contains the truth (its coverage) and its median length where the truth is known, how often each method is defined at all, and the mean and median error on the subset of repetitions in which all six methods are defined, since the conditional and hybrid methods break down exactly where selection matters most, at an exact tie for first.

Setting	Estimator	Mean error (SE)	Median error	RMSE	Coverage	Length	Defined	Mean, common	Median, common
Known truth, 500 tasks	reported	+0.92 (0.08)	+1.00	1.85	0.94	7.0	100%	+0.95	+1.00
	bootstrap	+0.08 (0.09)	+0.04	1.71	0.95	6.6	100%	+0.12	+0.07
	iterated bootstrap	−0.02 (0.09)	−0.11	1.77	0.94	6.6	100%	+0.03	−0.09
	conditional	+0.05 (0.11)	+0.23	2.10	0.98	9.4	90%	+0.05	+0.23
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.05 (0.11)	+0.23	2.10	0.98	9.5	90%	+0.05	+0.23
	zoom interval (ZF)	+0.92 (0.08)	+1.00	1.85	0.99	10.8	100%	+0.95	+1.00
Equal leaders, 500 tasks	reported	+2.19 (0.08)	+2.15	2.70	0.83	7.3	100%	+2.23	+2.35
	bootstrap	+0.65 (0.08)	+0.67	1.81	0.93	6.6	100%	+0.70	+0.71
	iterated bootstrap	+0.35 (0.09)	+0.32	1.80	0.93	6.6	100%	+0.41	+0.39
	conditional	+0.30 (0.14)	+0.57	2.60	0.97	15.0	86%	+0.30	+0.57
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.30 (0.14)	+0.57	2.60	0.97	10.6	86%	+0.30	+0.57
	zoom interval (ZF)	+2.19 (0.08)	+2.15	2.70	0.99	11.6	100%	+2.23	+2.35
Held-out tasks	reported	+2.04 (0.16)	+2.40	4.06	–	9.9	100%	+2.14	+2.40
	bootstrap	+0.52 (0.16)	+0.63	3.68	–	9.2	100%	+0.66	+0.65
	iterated bootstrap	+0.30 (0.17)	+0.41	3.71	–	9.2	100%	+0.45	+0.42
	conditional	+0.72 (0.20)	+0.94	4.12	–	15.7	82%	+0.72	+0.94
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.72 (0.20)	+0.94	4.12	–	14.2	82%	+0.72	+0.94
	zoom interval (ZF)	+2.04 (0.16)	+2.40	4.06	–	15.7	100%	+2.14	+2.40
Held-out repositories (cluster)	reported	+3.48 (0.17)	+2.98	5.21	–	9.9	100%	+3.90	+3.70
	bootstrap	+1.81 (0.18)	+1.59	4.34	–	15.6	100%	+2.22	+2.13
	iterated bootstrap	+1.85 (0.18)	+1.97	4.48	–	15.6	100%	+2.24	+2.37
	conditional	+3.38 (0.24)	+3.71	5.90	–	13.1	82%	+3.38	+3.71
	hybrid (AKM)	+3.43 (0.23)	+3.71	5.82	–	12.2	82%	+3.43	+3.71
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.48 (0.17)	+2.98	5.21	–	13.5	100%	+3.90	+3.70

Table 8: Winner's-curse correction on SWE-bench Verified, at least 400 repetitions per setting. Error is estimate minus target in percentage points; positive means overstated. Coverage is shown only where the truth is known; length is the median length of the 95% interval in points. The zoom interval's point estimate is the reported score. The last two columns use the repetitions in which all six estimators are defined.

Results. In the known-truth runs the winner's reported score is too high by 0.9 points at 500 tasks, 1.7 at 250 and 3.6 at 100; with equally able leaders by 2.2 at 500 tasks and 3.0 at 250; and on real held-out tasks by 2.0 points. After the iterated bootstrap correction 0.0 points remain at 500 tasks (standard error 0.09), +0.3 with equal leaders and +0.3 on held-out tasks, so it removes about 84% and 85% of the inflation in the last two cases; the plain bootstrap removes 74% on held-out tasks. These percentages carry simulation errors of about ±8 points, and the held-out repetitions are different splits of one board, so they are not independent. When the held-out half is made of other repositories, the repository-resampling iterated correction removes 47%, so a benchmark whose tasks drift away from the ones the winner was picked on will still overstate its winner. The correction removes the inflation but does not make the winner's score more precise: on held-out tasks the root mean squared error of the iterated bootstrap (3.7) is not below that of the plain bootstrap (3.7), because most of the error in one system's score is ordinary sampling noise, not selection. On the common subset the conditional method, which is median-unbiased by construction, has a median error of +0.6 with equal leaders against +0.4 for the iterated bootstrap, but it is defined in only 86% of those runs. The hybrid interval fails only at an exact tie for first and never runs off to infinity: with equal leaders it contains the truth in 0.97 of runs with a median length of 10.6 points, against 0.97 and 15.0 for the conditional interval, 0.93 and 6.6 for the iterated bootstrap, and 0.99 and 11.6 for the zoom interval, which leaves the point estimate as reported; the hybrid estimate's median error on the common subset is +0.6 points. The hybrid estimate came out identical to the conditional one in every setting we ran, because the wide first-stage interval seldom bites at these sample sizes; its gain over the conditional method is the shorter interval, and on held-out tasks it leaves +0.7 points of inflation against +0.3 for the iterated bootstrap. The two baselines do not change the recommendation: the iterated bootstrap has the smallest bias among estimates that still work at a tie, and the hybrid interval is the one to report when a guarantee under normality is wanted. In the known-truth runs the 95% iterated interval contains the truth more often than the interval around the reported score, 0.90 against 0.83 at 100 tasks and 0.94 against 0.94 at 500; it stays below the promised 95% when tasks are few. On Lite the

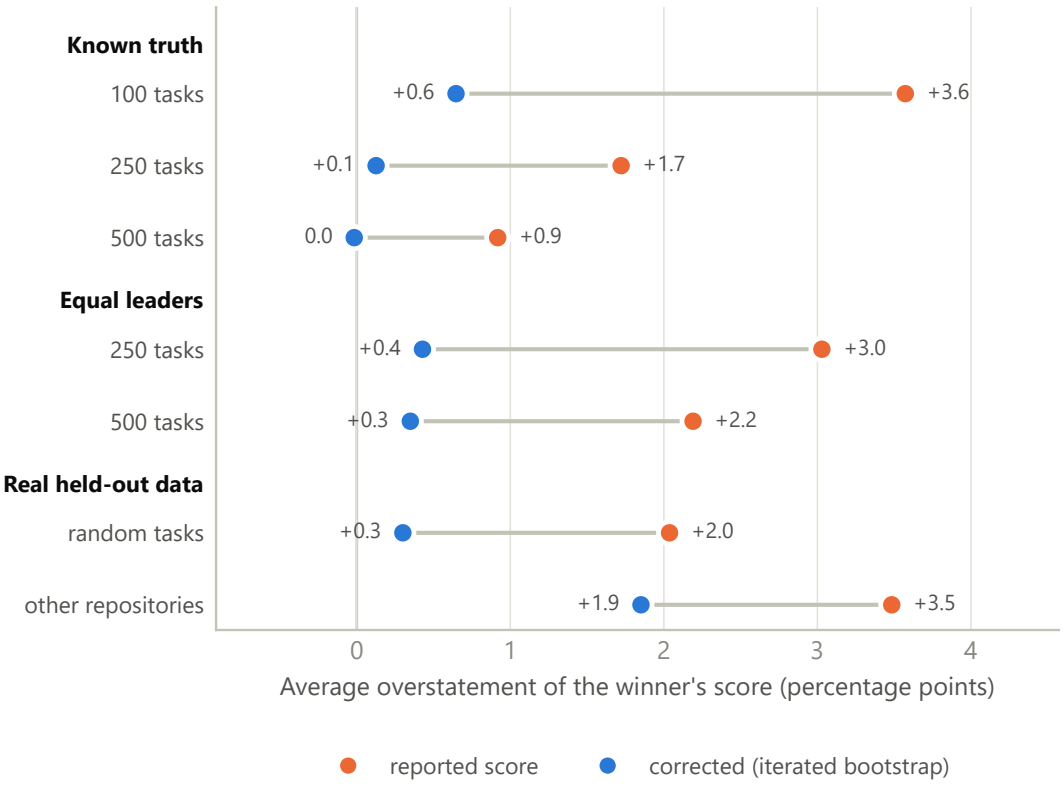


Figure 2: Average overstatement of the winner's score before and after the iterated bootstrap correction, on SWE-bench Verified. Orange: the reported score. Blue: the corrected score. The top two groups have known truth; the bottom group uses real held-out data, where the target is the winner's score on tasks that were not used to pick it.

iterated correction removes 74% on held-out tasks but overshoots on held-out repositories (mean error −0.6 points against 2.2 for the reported score, with selection halves of only 120 to 180 tasks). On Terminal-Bench (Appendix Table 20) the known-truth and equal-leaders results point the same way, but on real held-out halves of 44 tasks the iterated correction overshoots (mean error −1.2 points against 2.0 for the reported score), so the correction is not guaranteed to help on very small benchmarks. On LiveBench (Appendix Table 21) equally able leaders are inflated by 3.9 points, of which the iterated bootstrap leaves +0.5 and the hybrid 0.0; on held-out halves of its questions there is no inflation to remove (-0.5 for the reported score), because its leader is far ahead of the field, and the corrections leave it nearly untouched (−0.6 and −0.5).

5.4 Do the rank intervals and the set of possible best systems contain the truth?

We use the known-truth setting again (300 repetitions; Table 9). The 95% rank interval contains the true rank for 0.96 (250 tasks) and 0.96 (500 tasks) of all systems, for 0.95 and 0.96 of the ten truly best systems, and for 0.96 and 0.97 of the winners. When the top 20 systems are equally able, a leader's "true rank" is not well defined: if tied systems all count as rank 1 the interval contains it for only 0.44 and 0.42 of the leaders, if they count as the average of the tied ranks for 0.95 and 0.95, and it overlaps the block of tied ranks in 1.00 and 1.00 of cases. The intervals show how much a rank moves when the tasks are redrawn and should not be read as confidence intervals for a true

Tasks	Known truth: interval covers true rank all	true top 10	selected winner	Equal leaders: interval covers rank 1 (min)	average rank	tied block	Equal leaders: confidence set all	contains each leader	median size
250	0.96	0.95	0.96	0.44	0.95	1.00	0.88	0.99	28
500	0.96	0.96	0.97	0.42	0.95	1.00	0.88	0.99	23

Table 9: How often the 95% rank intervals and the set of possible best systems contain the truth, SWE-bench Verified, known-truth simulation. Equal leaders: the 20 top systems have equal true ability; the three conventions treat their true rank as 1, as the average of the tied ranks, or as the whole tied block.

Board	Systems	Tasks	Top-rank freq.	95% set	Records sig.	Holm	Repository-level	MDD (pts)	Leader (%): reported → adjusted
SWE-bench Verified	135	500	0.35	14	6/30	2	1/30	4.3	79.2 → 78.1
SWE-bench Lite	84	300	0.47	5	3/15	1	1/15	6.7	60.3 → 58.7
SWE-bench Test	24	2,294	1.00	1	9/13	9	7/13	2.2	52.6 → 52.6
SWE-bench Multimodal	12	510	0.38	5	1/7	0	1/7	3.8	36.5 → 35.3
SWE-bench Multilingual	14	300	0.54	9	0/0	0	0/0	7.2	72.7 → 71.2
Terminal-Bench 2	67	89	0.80	10	1/9	1	–	7.9	89.9 → 89.0
All boards					20/74	13	10/65		

Table 10: Audit summary. Top-rank freq.: share of redraws of the tasks in which the leader has the top score. 95% set: number of systems that could be the true best. Records sig.: record steps clearly better than the previous record at the 5% level (selective exact paired test, tasks as the unit) over all record steps. Holm: still clearly better after the Holm correction within the board. Repository-level: the same count with repositories as the unit, the cautious one. MDD: smallest true gap the board catches with 80% power. Last column: the leader's reported score and its winner's-curse adjustment (iterated bootstrap); where two systems tie for first, the leader is the one that ranks first more often.

rank when leaders are close [36, 38]. The set of possible best systems behaves differently: in the same runs it contained each of the equally able leaders in 0.99 (250 tasks) and 0.99 (500 tasks) of repetitions, with a median size of 28 and 23 against 20 tied systems, so it keeps each tied leader at the promised rate without being much larger than the tied block. Table 18 shows how often the observed winner really is one of the best systems in the known-truth runs: 0.70 at 500 tasks, 0.65 at 250 and 0.39 at 100.

6 Audit of six agent leaderboards, with a non-agent comparison

Records. Only 20 of 74 record steps (27%) are clearly better than the record they replaced by the selective test, and 13 (18%) after Holm; the two-sided test finds the same 20 steps, and the one-sided test at 5%, which wrongly rejects about 8.0% of lucky steps in simulation, finds 24. The split by benchmark size is stark: 9 of 13 on SWE-bench Test, 11 of 61 on the five boards with at most 510 tasks. Among the 35 steps that won by less than two points, 0 pass the test. Table 12 shows how the count moves with the choices we made: the repository-level test, the cautious one where tasks share repositories (Section 5), leaves 10 of the 65 SWE-bench steps against 19 with the task-level test, and ordering same-date submissions worst first creates more steps (99) of which 29% pass, so the share of records we cannot confirm barely changes. A record that does not pass is not shown to be equal to the one before it: for those records the margin could plausibly be as large as 4.6 points on Verified (the median 97.5% upper bound; 7.2 on Lite, 9.9 on Terminal-Bench), so gains of that size are neither shown nor ruled out. These are single-run submissions.

Board	Records	Unadjusted	Holm	Spending	Fallback	LORD++	LORD++ (polyhedral)	Spending, certified baseline	Tenure, certified baseline
SWE-bench Verified	30	6	2	2	2	2	2	7/56	6/71
SWE-bench Lite	15	3	1	1	1	1	1	4/31	4/31
SWE-bench Test	13	9	9	7	7	9	9	9/13	7/13
SWE-bench Multimodal	7	1	0	0	0	0	0	2/8	2/8
SWE-bench Multilingual	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0/0	0/0
Terminal-Bench 2	9	1	1	1	1	1	1	1/37	1/37
All boards	74	20	13	11	11	13	13	23/145	20/160

Table 11: Records certified by each rule, run in date order with the exact selective p-value unless noted. Unadjusted: selective exact test at 5% per step. Holm: looking back over the finished chain. Spending and fallback (both with the proved whole-chain guarantee) and LORD++ (checked by simulation): live levels. Certified baseline: every submission that beats the last certified record is tested (shown as certified/tested); the tenure levels carry the whole-chain guarantee of Corollary 3, the test-counting spending levels are checked by simulation.

Board	Steps	Selective (primary)	Two-sided	One-sided	Repository-level	Worst-first ordering
SWE-bench Verified	30	6	6	6	1	9/36
SWE-bench Lite	15	3	3	6	1	4/20
SWE-bench Test	13	9	9	10	7	13/17
SWE-bench Multimodal	7	1	1	1	1	1/7
SWE-bench Multilingual	0	0	0	0	0	1/10
Terminal-Bench 2	9	1	1	1	–	1/9
All boards	74	20	20	24	10 (of 65)	29/99

Table 12: Number of record steps that pass at the 5% level under five choices: the primary selective exact test with best-first ordering of same-date submissions, the two-sided exact test, the one-sided test at 5%, the repository-level sign-flip test (the cautious count), and worst-first ordering (more steps, shown as passing/steps).

Certified records. Run in date order, the live rules certify fewer records than Holm does looking back (Table 11): alpha-spending 11 and online fallback 11, the two rules with the proved guarantee, and LORD++, checked by simulation, 13 of the 74 leaderboard records, against 13 for Holm and 20 with no correction at all; the polyhedral p-value, which also allows for the holder's selection, gives 13 under LORD++. On these chains no two records in a row are both genuine and large enough to see, so the fallback rule certifies the same 11 records as spending, and the same 2 of the 4 LiveBench records (Table 14). With 95% confidence every record certified by either rule is genuine, so the six boards hold at least 11 records that beat the one before them task by task. With the certified baseline (Corollary 3), every submission that beats the last certified record is tested: the tenure rule, which carries the whole-chain guarantee, certifies 20 of 160 tested submissions across the boards, test-counting alpha-spending 23 of 145, and LORD++ 26 of 132. Figure 3 shows the leaderboard record line and the certified record line under the tenure rule on Verified and Lite: on Verified the certified leader changes 6 times in 135 submissions, against 30 leaderboard records.

Resolution. Figure 4 compares the smallest gap each board can reliably see with the gaps records are claimed by. SWE-bench Verified catches true gaps of 4.3 points with 80% power (95% interval from redrawing tasks 3.8 to 4.7; 4.8 with repository-level variance), calls a typical margin significant from about 3.0 points, and its typical record wins by 1.5; seeing a one-point gap would take about 9,300 tasks (interval 7,100 to 10,800) and a two-point gap about 2,300. Lite can see 6.7 points against a typical record margin of 3.0, Multimodal 3.8 against 1.2, Terminal-Bench 2 7.9 against 4.0 with 89 tasks, and SWE-bench Test 2.2 against 3.3, the one board whose typical record is bigger than the smallest gap it can see. Table 13 gives how far back a record has to be compared before

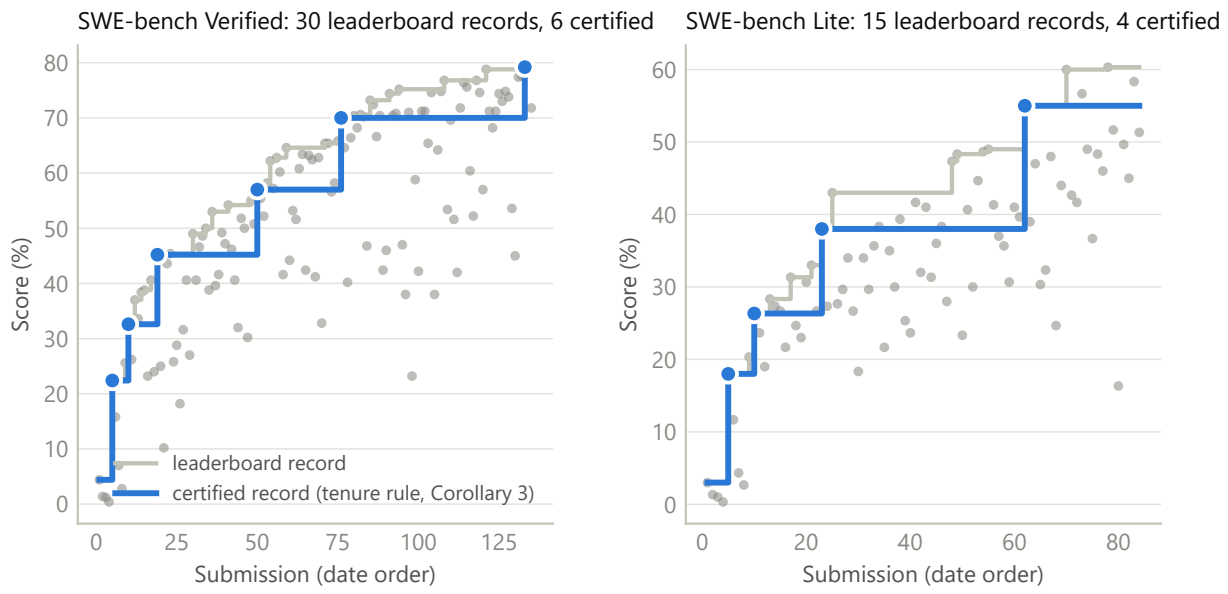


Figure 3: Leaderboard records and certified records in submission order. Gray dots: all submissions. Gray step: the leaderboard record. Blue step and dots: the certified record under the tenure rule of Corollary 3, which changes only when a submission is certified against the last certified record.

Board	Median margin (pts)	Median lag	Beats previous record	Beats no earlier record
SWE-bench Verified	1.5	3	20%	0%
SWE-bench Lite	3.0	2	20%	0%
SWE-bench Test	3.3	1	69%	0%
SWE-bench Multimodal	1.2	2	14%	14%
Terminal-Bench 2	4.0	3	11%	0%

Table 13: Lag analysis. Typical (median) margin of a record; median number of records back one must go before a record is clearly better than that earlier record (lag); the share of records clearly better than the one they replaced; and the share clearly better than no earlier record on the board.

it is clearly better.

Ranks. Figure 5 shows the leaders. On Verified the two tied leaders rank first in 0.35 and 0.32 of redraws of the tasks, and 14 systems could be the true best (20 with the all-pairs bound; 21 when repositories are redrawn). Terminal-Bench 2 shows the opposite case: the leader is first in 0.80 of redraws, yet with 89 tasks 10 systems still cannot be ruled out, because systems well below the leader cannot be excluded with so few tasks. A clear leader and a long list of possible best systems can both be true: the set keeps each truly best system at about the promised rate but cannot exclude systems well below the leader with so few tasks, so its size overstates how many systems really have a shot.

Adjusted winners. The winner's-curse adjustment of the leader's score, which covers luck in which tasks were drawn and nothing else, is in the last column of Table 10. On Verified the leader's reported 79.2% becomes 78.1% (95% interval 74.9 to 81.5); on Lite 60.3% becomes 58.7% (53.4 to 63.7). On SWE-bench Test the adjustment is tiny, because the leader is far ahead and the

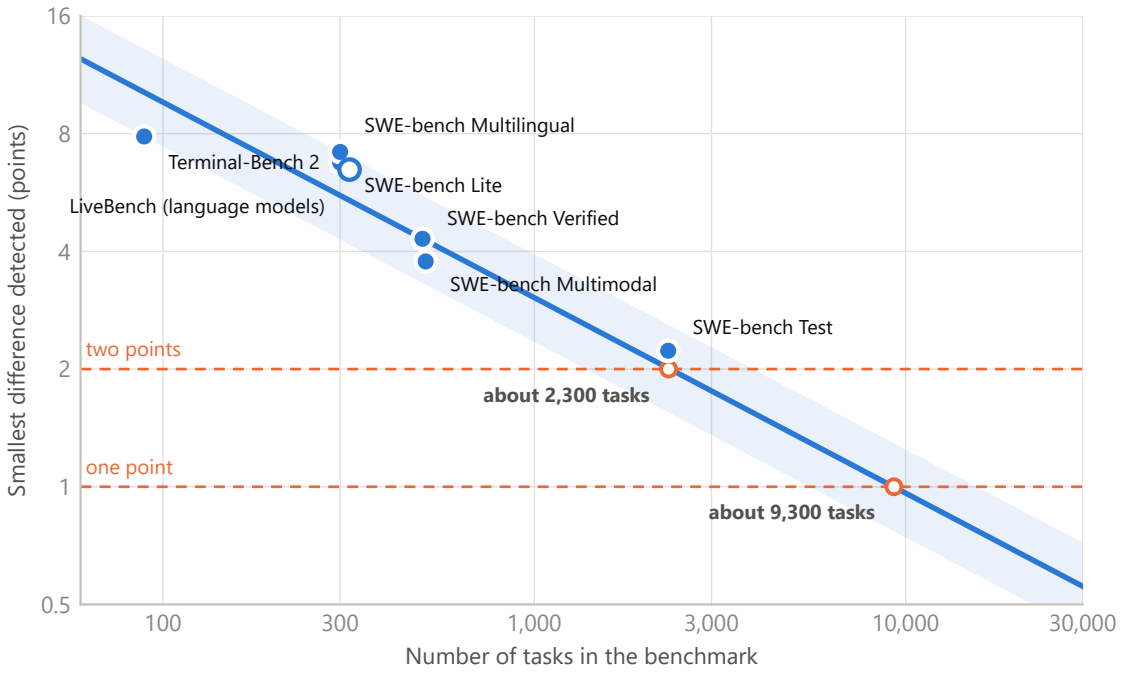


Figure 4: What a point costs. The smallest true gap a benchmark can catch with 80% power in the two-sided paired test at the 5% level, against the number of tasks (both axes logarithmic). The line uses SWE-bench Verified's task-by-task spread and the band spans the boards; orange circles mark the number of tasks Verified would need to see one- and two-point gaps. Filled dots are the six agent boards; the hollow dot is LiveBench, the language-model comparison.

benchmark is large. Tuning on public tasks is not covered, so the true inflation may be larger. The conditional method breaks down on Verified and Multimodal, where the top is an exact tie, and gives 55.7% on Lite and 89.9% on Terminal-Bench.

Run randomness on Terminal-Bench. Terminal-Bench runs each task several times, which lets us split the noise in a score into two parts: which tasks were drawn, and the agent giving different answers from one run to the next. For the 20 strongest systems, run-to-run randomness is a median 36% (range 14 to 64%) of the per-task variance of a single-run score, and 10% of a five-run score; for the difference between neighbouring top-10 systems it is 62% with one run and 20% with five. So a single-run coding-agent score carries run noise of about the same size as task-sampling noise, something the SWE-bench boards, with one run per submission, cannot show.

Development selection, seen through repeated runs. How much teams gain by quietly trying several versions before submitting cannot be measured from one run per system, but the Terminal-Bench submissions that ran the whole benchmark several times show the scale of its simplest form. 24 kept submissions have at least two complete jobs (median 5); the spread (standard deviation) of a submission's score across its jobs has median 1.7 points (middle half of submissions 1.0 to 2.5), and a team that had reported its best job instead of the average of its jobs would have gained a median 1.9 points (mean 2.7, at most 12.9). As a rough guide to scale, picture a team that tries V versions whose scores scatter like repeated runs and submits the best: the expected gain is $\mathbb{E}[\max_{v \le V} Z_v]$ times that spread, 1.0 points for two versions, 2.0 for five and 2.7 for ten,

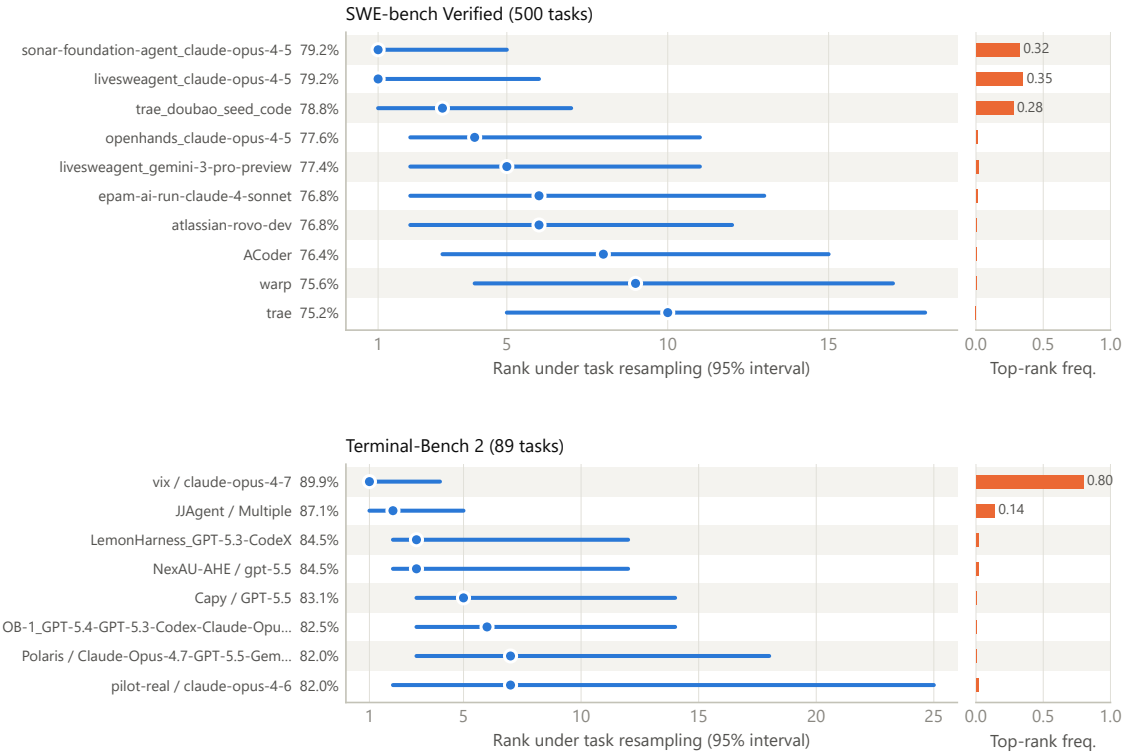


Figure 5: Rank intervals (95%, from redrawing the tasks) for the leading systems. The dot is the observed rank and the reported score follows each name. Orange bars: share of redraws in which the system ranks first.

about the same size as the winner's-curse inflation from task sampling and as this board's typical record margin (2.0 against 4.0 points). The leaderboard reports the average over jobs, so this is a bound on what reporting the best run would add, not a finding that anyone did it, and picking among versions that differ by more than run noise can add more.

A non-agent comparison. The procedures are not special to agents, and LiveBench shows what they return on a leaderboard of language models scored automatically question by question (Table 14). With 318 questions it can see gaps no finer than Lite can (minimum detectable difference 6.5 points, about 13,300 questions to see one point). Its 4 record steps under our main ordering win by a typical 5.8 points, above the board's critical margin of 4.5; 4 pass the unadjusted test, 1 Holm, and the live rules certify 2 (alpha-spending), 2 (online fallback) and 0 (LORD++); under the worst-first ordering of the 8 models that share the first date there are 11 steps, 6 of them clearly better. Its leader ranks first in 1.00 of redraws and is the only system that could be best, so the winner's-curse correction leaves its score where it is (77.6% to 77.7%). Four records are too few to compare with the agent boards, and the board is a reconstruction (three of six categories, partial credit, models dated by their first judgment in a snapshot file); what the comparison shows is that the tools apply unchanged, and that on a board that can see the same gaps it is the size of the margins that moves the counts.

	LiveBench	SWE-bench Verified	Terminal-Bench 2
Type of system	language model	agent	agent
Per-task score	credit in $[0, 1]$	pass or fail	mean of 1 to 10 trials
Systems	94	135	67
Tasks	318	500	89
Record steps	4	30	9
Distinguishable (two-sided exact)	4	6	1
After Holm	1	2	1
Certified, LORD++	0	2	1
Certified, alpha-spending	2	2	1
Certified, online fallback	2	2	1
Median record margin (pts)	5.8	1.5	4.0
Minimum detectable difference (pts)	6.5	4.3	7.9
Tasks to resolve one point	13,300	9,300	5,500
Leader's top-rank frequency	1.00	0.35	0.80
Systems tied at the top	1	2	1
95% confidence set of the best	1	14	10
Leader's score, reported $\to$ corrected (%)	77.6 $\to$ 77.7	79.2 $\to$ 78.1	89.9 $\to$ 89.0

Table 14: The non-agent comparison. LiveBench (language models) beside the agent board with the longest record chain and the smallest agent board. Certified counts are from the live rules run in date order on the leaderboard baseline.

7 The honestboard package

`honestboard` (it needs only numpy and scipy) implements everything above. A `Board` holds the systems-by-tasks table, with loaders for JSON, CSV and a checkout of the SWE-bench `experiments` repository. `Board.check_claim(system)` returns, in one call, the observed rank and its interval, how often the system ranks first, whether it could be the best, the paired test against its closest rival, and, for the leader, the winner's-curse-corrected score. `Board.record_audit()` walks through a leaderboard's history and tests every record step; `Board.resolution()` gives the smallest gap the board can see and the tasks needed for a one-point gap. A command line (`python -m honestboard report BOARD.json`) prints the same, and `pr-check` reads a checkout of a leaderboard repository and prints a Markdown report on one new submission, so that a maintainer can post it on every pull request. The package has unit tests that include simulations checking that the set of possible best systems and the conditional method contain the truth as often as promised, brute-force checks of the cut-off limits and of the sign-flip enumeration, tie handling, input validation and the covariance estimator.

8 Limitations

- **Task sampling only.** We model luck in which tasks were chosen (Table 1). Tuning on the public tasks is not modelled, and it is where much benchmark inflation comes from [44, 52]; nothing here says how much of a leaderboard's progress is tuning; the best-of-runs bound from Terminal-Bench covers only the case where the versions tried differ by run noise, and the private-tries simulation prices the simplest form of tuning (Table 4) but not training on the tasks. Run-to-run randomness is not modelled for SWE-bench, where submissions are single runs; on Terminal-Bench it is a third to a half of the noise in a single-run score.
- **What the numbers are about.** Our statements are about more tasks of the benchmark's

own kind, not about unseen repositories or real-world use. The held-out-repository results show how quickly the correction gets worse when the kind of task changes.

- **Tasks are not independent.** Tasks from one repository move together. The task-level tests and intervals treat tasks as independent, which makes things look more certain than they are: with repository-specific strengths of the size the real board's standard errors suggest, the task-level record test wrongly rejects 10 to 25% of lucky record steps (Table 5). The repository-level test holds its level but has little power with a dozen repositories (Multilingual has 41), and its standard error comes out too small when one repository dominates; we report both counts and call the repository-level one the cautious one.

- **Record test and certification.** Record steps are selected for being records. The selective test wrongly rejects at most 5% under both nulls, at every chain position we simulated and on split halves of the real boards; it is exact for a fixed holder and cautious for a holder that is the best so far, under the task-level null (Proposition 1), which asks more than equal true scores and assumes outcomes independent across tasks; the case where that null fails (tweaked copies of earlier systems), the certified baseline with test-counting levels (no proof, per step or over the chain), and the polyhedral variant rest on simulation. The alpha-spending guarantee is exact given per-step validity but loses power late in a chain; LORD++'s guarantee assumes independent p-values, ours are linked through shared tasks, and we rely on simulation for it.

- **No theory for the correction.** The iterated bootstrap is justified by simulation only; the conditional method is exact only under normality and breaks down at ties; the correction overshoots on the smallest benchmark; its intervals contain the truth less often than promised at small sizes. The hybrid and zoom baselines carry coverage guarantees under normality, and Section 5 reports how they compare.

- **The comparison board.** LiveBench's judgments file covers three of its six categories, its questions change over time, and we date a model by its first judgment, so its record chain is only an approximation of the leaderboard's history; its per-question scores are partial credit rather than pass or fail.

- **Rank intervals.** They show how much a rank moves when the tasks are redrawn and do not contain a true rank when leaders are tied; use the set of possible best systems for that question.

- **Same-date ordering.** Which steps count as records depends on how same-date submissions are ordered; we report both extremes and prefer the one that invents no record. The best-first challenger is the best of its date, which the per-date factor of Section 3 corrects for; the proofs assume that, apart from this, which systems were submitted and in what order does not depend on their results, which a submission time finer than the day would make true without any correction.

- **Missing task-by-task data.** 47 of 182 Verified submissions have no task-by-task file. They are recent and score high; by overall score none would have held the record, but they are missing from every other analysis of that board, and other leaderboards may have similar gaps.

- **Terminal-Bench handling.** Most job files do not say which benchmark version they ran, pooled submissions have uneven run counts, and runs that errored are counted as failures; other choices would move its numbers.

- **No cross-benchmark test of the correction.** Few systems appear on two SWE-bench splits, they are old, and they are spread so widely that the winner is far ahead of the field, so there is no winner's curse to detect.

9 Recommendations

For benchmark maintainers: publish task-by-task results for every submission; call a record a new state of the art only when it is certified against the previous record by the selective record test, at a level set by the online fallback rule (or alpha-spending), whose guarantee needs no independence between steps, so that the error rate holds over the whole history, in the spirit of the Ladder mechanism [4]; LORD++ earns back more budget but is checked only by simulation here. On a board of a few hundred tasks this means that most records of a point or two will never be certified; that is the honest state of affairs, and the argument for growing the benchmark. Report the smallest gap the benchmark can see and the number of tasks needed to see a one-point gap, and expand or retire benchmarks that cannot see the gaps their leaderboards display. For authors: report paired intervals against the strongest baseline, say how many versions were tried on the benchmark so that the record test can be corrected for it (Section 5), and when claiming the top spot report the reported score, the winner's-curse-adjusted score and its interval together, with the hybrid interval where a coverage guarantee under normality is wanted, and say that tuning on public tasks is not covered. For readers: treat a margin below the board's critical margin (about 3.0 points on Verified) as unresolved, not as a tie. Appendix A lists ten things a leaderboard can adopt.

10 Conclusion

Leaderboards squeeze a big table of task-by-task results into one ranking. On the four agent boards with at most 510 tasks and at least one record, most records cannot be told apart from the record before them by a test that allows for how records are selected; on the 2,294-task SWE-bench Test most can. This is a statement about what the benchmarks can see, not a finding that the records are equal, and tuning on public tasks, which we do not model, is a separate source of inflation. The procedures work unchanged on a language-model leaderboard, LiveBench, whose four records are too few to compare with the agent boards. Task-by-task data, which several leaderboards already publish, is enough to say how much a record claim shows, and the live certification rules let a leaderboard say it at the moment the claim is made.

Use of AI assistance. The code, the analyses and the drafting of this paper were carried out with an AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) under the authors' direction; the authors specified the questions, the data and the methods, reviewed every result and every proof, and are responsible for the content. Three outside automated reviews were used to find errors before submission; their findings and the responses are recorded in the repository.

Reproducibility. The script `make_numbers.py` generates every number in this paper from the result files, so the text cannot disagree with the analysis. Data provenance, the command behind every table and figure, the pinned environment and the hashes of every data and result file are in the repository (`https://github.com/jopoku16/honestboard`, file `REPRODUCE.md`).

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A Reporting checklist for leaderboards

1. Publish per-task outcomes for every submission, in one table with the same task identifiers.
2. Publish the full task list, including tasks that no submission solved.
3. State the number of runs behind each score and the trial structure.
4. State the number of variants, prompts or configurations tried against the benchmark before the submission.
5. Order same-date submissions by an explicit rule (for example submission time).

6. Report each record's margin over the previous record with a paired interval, not only the score.

7. Mark a submission as a new state of the art only if it beats the previous record in a selection-aware paired test at a stated level, and say which test.

8. Report the benchmark's resolution: the smallest difference it detects with 80% power, and the number of tasks needed to resolve a one-point gap.

9. Report a confidence set of the best system next to the ranking.

10. Report the selection-corrected score of the current leader, and say that tuning against public tasks is not covered by the correction.

B What a maintainer sees

The package answers the questions of this paper for one submission in one call. Below is its output, unedited, for the current SWE-bench Verified leader and for the board as a whole; the `pr-check` command prints the same facts as a Markdown comment for a pull request. The leader ties the previous leader exactly (difference 0.0 points, so it set no record), and the board's latest record beat the record it replaced by just two tasks, for which the selective p-value is exactly one: the smallest possible record carries no evidence at all.

```
$ python -m honestboard check swebench_verified.json 20251215_livesweagent_claude-opus-4-5
20251215_livesweagent_claude-opus-4-5: score 79.2%, observed rank 1, 95% rank interval (1.0,
    6.0), top-rank freq.=0.35
Inside the 95% confidence set of the best: True (set size 14)
Paired test, 20251215_livesweagent_claude-opus-4-5 vs
    20251205_sonar-foundation-agent_claude-opus-4-5: difference +0.0 pts, one-sided exact
    p=0.566

$ python -m honestboard report swebench_verified.json
135 systems, 500 tasks

Leaders with 95% rank intervals and top-rank frequency:
  20251205_sonar-foundation-agent_claude-opus-4-5       79.2%  rank [1, 5]  top-rank freq.=0.32
  20251215_livesweagent_claude-opus-4-5                 79.2%  rank [1, 6]  top-rank freq.=0.35
  20250928_trae_doubao_seed_code                        78.8%  rank [1, 7]  top-rank freq.=0.28
  20251127_openhands_claude-opus-4-5                    77.6%  rank [2, 11]  top-rank freq.=0.01
  20251120_livesweagent_gemini-3-pro-preview            77.4%  rank [2, 11]  top-rank freq.=0.02
  20250804_epam-ai-run-claude-4-sonnet                  76.8%  rank [2, 13]  top-rank freq.=0.01
  20250902_atlassian-rovo-dev                           76.8%  rank [2, 12]  top-rank freq.=0.00
  20250819_ACoder                                       76.4%  rank [3, 15]  top-rank freq.=0.00
  20250901_warp                                         75.6%  rank [4, 17]  top-rank freq.=0.00
  20250612_trae                                         75.2%  rank [5, 18]  top-rank freq.=0.00

Confidence set of the best (95%): 14 of 135 systems cannot be ruled out as best.

Record claims: 30 steps, 6 beat the previous record at the 5% level (selective exact paired
    test, conditional on the record event), 2 after Holm correction.
Resolution: this board detects differences of about 4.3 points (80% power); resolving a 1-point
    gap would take about 9,277 tasks.

Winner 20251215_livesweagent_claude-opus-4-5: reported 79.2%, selection-adjusted estimate
    78.1%, 95% interval [74.9%, 81.5%] (naive [75.6%, 82.8%]).
  conditional method: estimate nan%, interval [-inf%, inf%] (unbounded when the winner's margin
    is about zero)
```

```
hybrid (Andrews, Kitagawa and McCloskey): estimate nan%, interval [nan%, nan%] (undefined at
  an exact tie for first)
zoom interval (Zrnic and Fithian): [73.7%, 84.7%] over 47 plausible winners
```

C The record-test calibration fitted to other boards

The simulations of Section 5 are fitted to SWE-bench Verified. Table 15 repeats the false-rejection and power study with the model fitted to SWE-bench Lite, Terminal-Bench 2 and LiveBench (their own task difficulties, base score and copula correlation ρ, the last tuned to each board's task-by-task spread), at 300, 500 and 2,000 tasks. With the model fitted to Lite the selective test wrongly rejects 4.1% of selected null steps at 500 tasks (one-sided 8.3%), fitted to Terminal-Bench 3.3% (7.5%) and fitted to LiveBench 4.0% (9.0%).

Fitted board	ρ	Tasks	Selected-step null	Global null, per step	Global null, first step	Power at the MDD
SWE-bench Verified	0.29	300	3.7%	0.3%	0.7%	0.77
	0.29	500	3.7%	0.5%	1.0%	0.78
	0.29	2,000	4.4%	0.8%	2.1%	0.77
SWE-bench Lite	0.37	300	3.9%	0.5%	1.5%	0.76
	0.37	500	4.1%	0.8%	2.1%	0.77
	0.37	2,000	4.1%	0.9%	2.4%	0.78
Terminal-Bench 2	0.84	300	3.1%	0.9%	2.1%	0.74
	0.84	500	3.3%	0.4%	1.2%	0.75
	0.84	2,000	4.1%	0.7%	2.0%	0.78
LiveBench	0.64	300	3.5%	1.0%	2.8%	0.77
	0.64	500	4.0%	0.7%	2.0%	0.77
	0.64	2,000	4.4%	0.9%	2.6%	0.77

Table 15: The record test with the simulation model fitted to each of four boards. Selected-step null and global null: how often the selective test wrongly rejects at the 5% level among record steps (global null: averaged over the chain, and at the first step). Power at the MDD: how often the selective test catches a gap equal to the formula's minimum detectable difference, target 0.80.

D Proof of Lemma 1

Write $T_n(k) = \sum_{j\ge k} \binom{n}{j}$, so that $p_{\mathrm{sel}}(k,n) = T_n(k)/T_n(\lfloor n/2\rfloor + 1)$ for a challenger with $k > n/2$ wins among n discordant tasks. Pascal's rule gives $\sum_{j\ge k+1} \binom{n+1}{j} = 2T_n(k) - \binom{n}{k}$ and $\sum_{j\ge k} \binom{n+1}{j} = 2T_n(k) + \binom{n}{k-1}$. The ratio $T_n(k)/\binom{n}{k} = 1 + r_k + r_k r_{k+1} + \cdots$ with $r_j = (n-j)/(j+1)$ decreasing in j is decreasing in k, and so is $T_n(k)/\binom{n}{k-1} = r_{k-1} + r_{k-1}r_k + \cdots$.

A challenger win is added $(k, n \to k+1, n+1)$. For even $n = 2m$ the denominators are $T_n(m+1)$ and $2T_n(m+1) + \binom{n}{m}$, and the claim $\{2T_n(k) - \binom{n}{k}\}/\{2T_n(m+1) + \binom{n}{m}\} \le T_n(k)/T_n(m+1)$ reduces to $-\binom{n}{k}T_n(m+1) \le T_n(k)\binom{n}{m}$, which holds. For odd $n = 2m+1$ the denominators are $T_n(m+1)$ and $2T_n(m+1) - \binom{n}{m+1}$, and the claim reduces to $T_n(k)/\binom{n}{k} \le T_n(m+1)/\binom{n}{m+1}$ for $k \ge m+1$, which is the monotonicity of the first ratio.

A holder win is added $(k, n \to k, n+1)$. For even $n = 2m$ the claim $\{2T_n(k) + \binom{n}{k-1}\}/\{2T_n(m+1) + \binom{n}{m}\} \ge T_n(k)/T_n(m+1)$ reduces to $T_n(k)/\binom{n}{k-1} \le T_n(m+1)/\binom{n}{m}$ for $k \ge m+1$, the monotonicity of the second ratio. For odd n it reduces to $\binom{n}{k-1}T_n(m+1) + T_n(k)\binom{n}{m+1} \ge 0$. □

E A normal-theory selective p-value for a record step

With $\widehat{p} \sim N(\theta, \widehat{\Sigma})$, the event that b is a record at position k and a was the holder is the polyhedron $\{\widehat{p}_b > \widehat{p}_a,\ \widehat{p}_a \geq \widehat{p}_j\ \forall j < k\}$, and the polyhedral lemma [29] gives the truncated-normal law of the contrast $\widehat{p}_b - \widehat{p}_a$ on it, hence a one-sided selective p-value for $\theta_b \leq \theta_a$. Scores are pass counts over T, so they sit on a grid of spacing $1/T$, and the holder is often tied or one task apart from its closest earlier competitor. Without a correction that puts the statistic right on the edge of the cut-off region and the p-value collapses: in our simulations it wrongly rejected 14% of null steps at the 5% level even with the true covariance. Relaxing each constraint by half a grid step and taking the tail from half a step below the observed statistic (a continuity correction) brings the rate to 1 to 3%. We have no finite-sample guarantee for the corrected version and report it only as a comparison (Tables 7 and 11).

F Record ladders

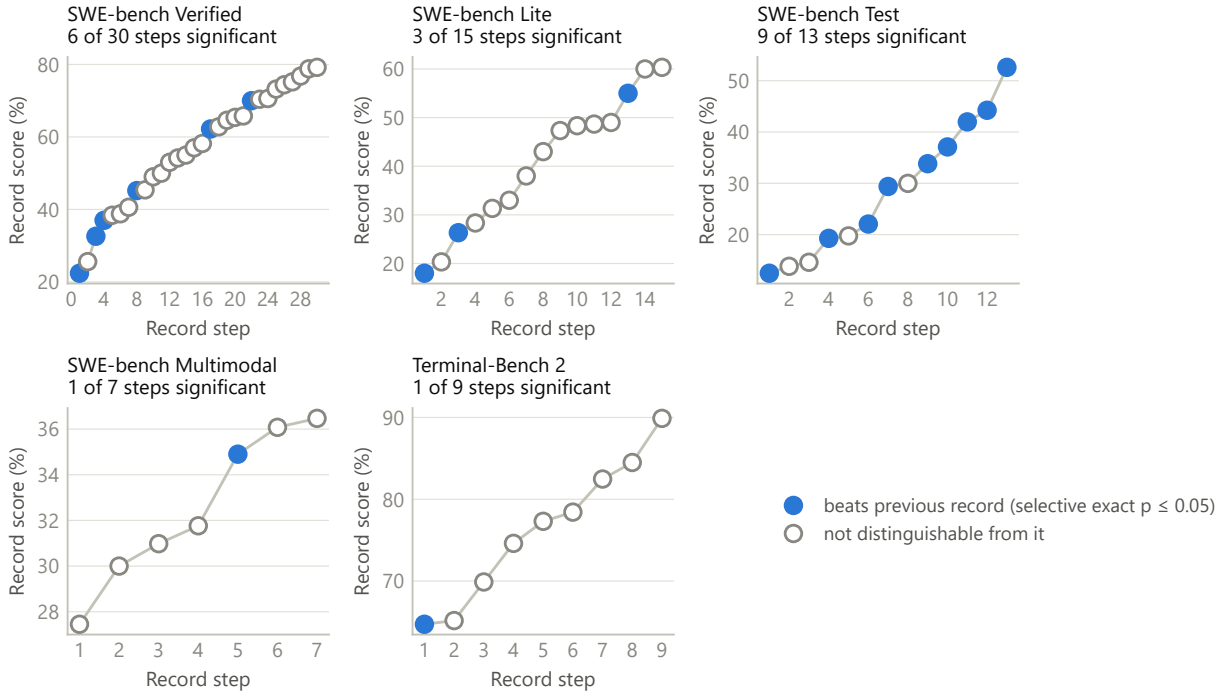


Figure 6: The record ladders of five leaderboards. A filled point is clearly better than the previous record (selective exact paired test at the 5% level); a hollow point is not.

G Full validation tables

Tasks	Step in the chain	Steps	selective	two-sided	one-sided
300	first (holder is the first submission)	576	0.7%	0.7%	3.1%
300	second	501	0.2%	0.2%	0.8%
300	third and later	621	0.0%	0.0%	0.2%
500	first (holder is the first submission)	575	1.0%	1.0%	4.0%
500	second	505	0.6%	0.6%	1.0%
500	third and later	625	0.0%	0.0%	0.2%
2,000	first (holder is the first submission)	578	2.1%	2.1%	4.8%
2,000	second	506	0.4%	0.4%	1.6%
2,000	third and later	729	0.0%	0.0%	0.1%

Table 16: Global null: how often the test wrongly rejects, by the step's position in the record chain. The first step compares against the first submission, which is only mildly lucky; later steps compare against the luckiest system so far.

Tasks	1 pt	2 pts	3 pts	5 pts	Power at the formula's MDD
300	0.05	0.13	0.27	0.67	0.77 (MDD 5.5 pts)
500	0.07	0.21	0.46	0.90	0.78 (MDD 4.2 pts)
2,000	0.23	0.72	0.98	1.00	0.77 (MDD 2.1 pts)

Table 17: How often the selective paired test catches a true gap of 1, 2, 3 and 5 points, and a gap equal to the minimum detectable difference given by the formula in Section 3. Fitted Verified model, baseline score 77%.

Tasks per benchmark	Winner is a truly best system (share of runs)	Set covers a truly best system when the winner is not	Median set size
100	0.39	1.00	34
250	0.65	1.00	19
500	0.70	0.99	12

Table 18: Known-truth simulation of ranking on SWE-bench Verified: how often the observed winner really is one of the best systems, and whether the set of possible best systems contains a truly best system when the winner is not one.

Setting	Estimator	Mean error (SE)	Median error	RMSE	Coverage	Length	Defined	Mean, common	Median, common
Known truth, 100 tasks	reported	+3.57 (0.19)	+3.80	5.25	0.83	15.1	100%	+3.63	+3.80
	bootstrap	+1.07 (0.21)	+1.00	4.26	0.88	14.0	100%	+1.23	+1.07
	iterated bootstrap	+0.65 (0.21)	+0.62	4.31	0.90	14.0	100%	+0.86	+0.81
	conditional	+2.51 (0.24)	+2.58	4.91	0.91	19.4	76%	+2.51	+2.58
	hybrid (AKM)	+2.51 (0.24)	+2.58	4.91	0.92	19.3	76%	+2.51	+2.58
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.57 (0.19)	+3.80	5.25	0.96	24.9	100%	+3.63	+3.80
Known truth, 250 tasks	reported	+1.72 (0.12)	+1.60	2.92	0.89	9.9	100%	+1.84	+2.00
	bootstrap	+0.32 (0.13)	+0.26	2.54	0.93	9.2	100%	+0.48	+0.39
	iterated bootstrap	+0.13 (0.13)	+0.12	2.60	0.91	9.2	100%	+0.31	+0.26
	conditional	+0.80 (0.15)	+0.92	2.91	0.94	13.2	86%	+0.80	+0.92
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.80 (0.15)	+0.92	2.91	0.94	13.3	86%	+0.80	+0.92
	zoom interval (ZF)	+1.72 (0.12)	+1.60	2.92	0.99	15.5	100%	+1.84	+2.00
Known truth, 500 tasks	reported	+0.92 (0.08)	+1.00	1.85	0.94	7.0	100%	+0.95	+1.00
	bootstrap	+0.08 (0.09)	+0.04	1.71	0.95	6.6	100%	+0.12	+0.07
	iterated bootstrap	−0.02 (0.09)	−0.11	1.77	0.94	6.6	100%	+0.03	−0.09
	conditional	+0.05 (0.11)	+0.23	2.10	0.98	9.4	90%	+0.05	+0.23
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.05 (0.11)	+0.23	2.10	0.98	9.5	90%	+0.05	+0.23
	zoom interval (ZF)	+0.92 (0.08)	+1.00	1.85	0.99	10.8	100%	+0.95	+1.00
Equal leaders, 250 tasks	reported	+3.03 (0.11)	+2.75	3.75	0.81	10.2	100%	+3.13	+2.75
	bootstrap	+0.86 (0.12)	+0.65	2.56	0.92	9.2	100%	+1.00	+0.78
	iterated bootstrap	+0.43 (0.13)	+0.24	2.57	0.93	9.2	100%	+0.60	+0.41
	conditional	+1.20 (0.18)	+1.21	3.32	0.96	17.9	78%	+1.20	+1.21
	hybrid (AKM)	+1.20 (0.18)	+1.21	3.32	0.96	14.8	78%	+1.20	+1.21
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.03 (0.11)	+2.75	3.75	0.97	16.5	100%	+3.13	+2.75
Equal leaders, 500 tasks	reported	+2.19 (0.08)	+2.15	2.70	0.83	7.3	100%	+2.23	+2.35
	bootstrap	+0.65 (0.08)	+0.67	1.81	0.93	6.6	100%	+0.70	+0.71
	iterated bootstrap	+0.35 (0.09)	+0.32	1.80	0.93	6.6	100%	+0.41	+0.39
	conditional	+0.30 (0.14)	+0.57	2.60	0.97	15.0	86%	+0.30	+0.57
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.30 (0.14)	+0.57	2.60	0.97	10.6	86%	+0.30	+0.57
	zoom interval (ZF)	+2.19 (0.08)	+2.15	2.70	0.99	11.6	100%	+2.23	+2.35
Held-out tasks	reported	+2.04 (0.16)	+2.40	4.06	–	9.9	100%	+2.14	+2.40
	bootstrap	+0.52 (0.16)	+0.63	3.68	–	9.2	100%	+0.66	+0.65
	iterated bootstrap	+0.30 (0.17)	+0.41	3.71	–	9.2	100%	+0.45	+0.42
	conditional	+0.72 (0.20)	+0.94	4.12	–	15.7	82%	+0.72	+0.94
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.72 (0.20)	+0.94	4.12	–	14.2	82%	+0.72	+0.94
	zoom interval (ZF)	+2.04 (0.16)	+2.40	4.06	–	15.7	100%	+2.14	+2.40
Held-out repositories (cluster, shift-adjusted)	reported	+3.48 (0.17)	+2.98	5.21	–	9.9	100%	+3.90	+3.70
	bootstrap	+1.81 (0.18)	+1.59	4.34	–	15.6	100%	+2.22	+2.13
	iterated bootstrap	+1.85 (0.18)	+1.97	4.48	–	15.6	100%	+2.24	+2.37
	conditional	+3.38 (0.24)	+3.71	5.90	–	13.1	82%	+3.38	+3.71
	hybrid (AKM)	+3.43 (0.23)	+3.71	5.82	–	12.2	82%	+3.43	+3.71
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.48 (0.17)	+2.98	5.21	–	13.5	100%	+3.90	+3.70
Held-out repositories (cluster, unadjusted)	reported	+3.82 (0.26)	+3.05	6.96	–	9.9	100%	+3.68	+2.69
	bootstrap	+2.14 (0.26)	+2.29	6.21	–	15.6	100%	+2.00	+1.67
	iterated bootstrap	+2.18 (0.27)	+2.22	6.46	–	15.6	100%	+2.03	+1.58
	conditional	+3.17 (0.31)	+2.01	7.12	–	13.1	82%	+3.17	+2.01
	hybrid (AKM)	+3.22 (0.31)	+2.03	7.08	–	12.2	82%	+3.22	+2.03
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.82 (0.26)	+3.05	6.96	–	13.5	100%	+3.68	+2.69
Held-out repositories (iid, shift-adjusted)	reported	+3.51 (0.17)	+3.04	5.22	–	9.7	100%	+3.90	+3.75
	bootstrap	+2.13 (0.17)	+1.48	4.45	–	9.1	100%	+2.57	+2.28
	iterated bootstrap	+1.98 (0.18)	+1.30	4.42	–	9.1	100%	+2.45	+2.04
	conditional	+2.85 (0.22)	+2.23	5.21	–	13.4	82%	+2.85	+2.23
	hybrid (AKM)	+2.85 (0.22)	+2.23	5.21	–	13.0	82%	+2.85	+2.23
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.51 (0.17)	+3.04	5.22	–	15.2	100%	+3.90	+3.75

Table 19: All validation settings on SWE-bench Verified. Columns as in Table 8. The held-out-repository rows show the cluster-resampling corrections against the shift-adjusted and the unadjusted target, and the task-resampling (iid) corrections against the shift-adjusted target.

Setting	Estimator	Mean error (SE)	Median error	RMSE	Coverage	Length	Defined	Mean, common	Median, common
Known truth, 89 tasks	reported	+1.19 (0.11)	+1.12	2.90	0.85	9.2	100%	+1.20	+1.12
	bootstrap	−0.06 (0.12)	−0.03	2.97	0.85	9.2	100%	−0.01	+0.01
	iterated bootstrap	−0.10 (0.13)	−0.07	3.11	0.83	9.2	100%	−0.03	−0.03
	conditional	−0.18 (0.17)	+0.44	4.15	0.91	10.5	96%	−0.18	+0.44
	hybrid (AKM)	−0.13 (0.15)	+0.43	3.73	0.91	10.7	97%	+0.01	+0.44
	zoom interval (ZF)	+1.19 (0.11)	+1.12	2.90	0.95	14.1	100%	+1.20	+1.12
Equal leaders, 89 tasks	reported	+2.66 (0.10)	+2.47	3.65	0.82	10.8	100%	+2.73	+2.69
	bootstrap	+0.83 (0.11)	+0.60	2.79	0.90	10.0	100%	+0.92	+0.76
	iterated bootstrap	+0.44 (0.11)	+0.24	2.79	0.90	10.0	100%	+0.55	+0.34
	conditional	+0.50 (0.16)	+0.89	3.80	0.94	18.2	88%	+0.50	+0.89
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.53 (0.16)	+0.89	3.75	0.94	14.5	88%	+0.53	+0.89
	zoom interval (ZF)	+2.66 (0.10)	+2.47	3.65	0.95	16.0	100%	+2.73	+2.69
Held-out tasks	reported	+1.98 (0.23)	+1.59	5.98	–	13.3	100%	+1.91	+1.12
	bootstrap	−0.71 (0.25)	−0.90	6.21	–	13.7	100%	−0.73	−0.94
	iterated bootstrap	−1.15 (0.26)	−1.21	6.52	–	13.7	100%	−1.15	−1.17
	conditional	−0.70 (0.32)	+0.12	7.72	–	17.6	94%	−0.70	+0.12
	hybrid (AKM)	−0.48 (0.30)	+0.07	7.14	–	16.7	95%	−0.39	+0.12
	zoom interval (ZF)	+1.98 (0.23)	+1.59	5.98	–	20.8	100%	+1.91	+1.12

Table 20: Validation on Terminal-Bench 2 (89 tasks, per-task rates from repeated trials; equal-leaders outcomes simulated with five trials).

Setting	Estimator	Mean error (SE)	Median error	RMSE	Coverage	Length	Defined	Mean, common	Median, common
Known truth, 318 questions	reported	+0.06 (0.11)	−0.01	2.12	0.94	8.1	100%	+0.06	−0.01
	bootstrap	−0.05 (0.11)	−0.03	2.22	0.93	7.9	100%	−0.05	−0.03
	iterated bootstrap	+0.08 (0.11)	+0.06	2.18	0.93	7.9	100%	+0.08	+0.06
	conditional	+0.06 (0.11)	−0.01	2.13	0.94	8.1	100%	+0.06	−0.01
	hybrid (AKM)	+0.06 (0.11)	−0.01	2.13	0.94	8.2	100%	+0.06	−0.01
	zoom interval (ZF)	+0.06 (0.11)	−0.01	2.12	0.99	12.1	100%	+0.06	−0.01
Equal leaders, 318 questions	reported	+3.88 (0.09)	+3.70	4.30	0.76	10.2	100%	+3.96	+4.01
	bootstrap	+1.03 (0.11)	+0.92	2.37	0.94	8.5	100%	+1.14	+0.93
	iterated bootstrap	+0.46 (0.12)	+0.27	2.35	0.95	8.5	100%	+0.59	+0.31
	conditional	−0.25 (0.24)	+0.62	4.54	0.97	24.1	87%	−0.25	+0.62
	hybrid (AKM)	−0.02 (0.23)	+0.62	4.22	0.97	14.6	87%	−0.02	+0.62
	zoom interval (ZF)	+3.88 (0.09)	+3.70	4.30	0.98	16.8	100%	+3.96	+4.01
Held-out questions	reported	−0.48 (0.21)	−0.66	4.22	–	11.5	100%	−0.48	−0.66
	bootstrap	−0.97 (0.22)	−1.06	4.58	–	11.5	100%	−0.97	−1.06
	iterated bootstrap	−0.62 (0.23)	−0.70	4.54	–	11.5	100%	−0.62	−0.70
	conditional	−0.50 (0.21)	−0.67	4.25	–	11.6	100%	−0.50	−0.67
	hybrid (AKM)	−0.50 (0.21)	−0.67	4.25	–	11.8	100%	−0.50	−0.67
	zoom interval (ZF)	−0.48 (0.21)	−0.66	4.22	–	18.0	100%	−0.48	−0.66

Table 21: Validation on LiveBench (318 questions, per-question credit in $[0, 1]$; equal-leaders outcomes simulated as pass or fail), 400 repetitions.